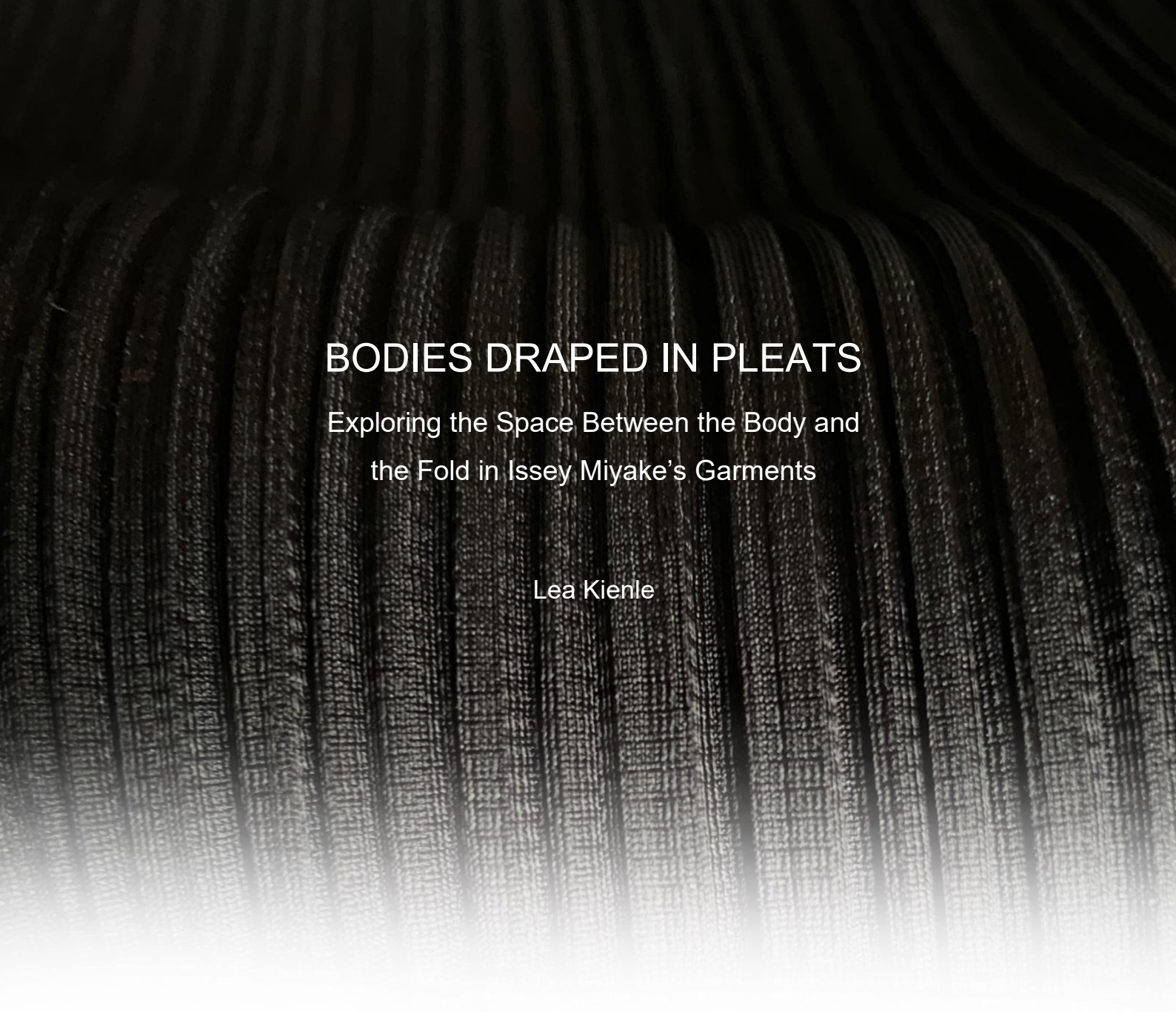


BODIES DRAPED IN PLEATS

Exploring the Space Between the Body and the Fold in Issey Miyake's Garments

Lea Kienle

Department of Media Studies
Stockholm University
Master Thesis / Fashion Studies (30 hp)
Spring 2025
Supervisor: Louise Thanem Wallenberg

Stockholms universitet

Abstract

The Japanese designer Issey Miyake disrupted the Western fashion landscape at the end of the 20th century by introducing simple and abstract designs that liberated the body from restrictive sartorial norms. Taking a closer look at the heat-pressed polyester folds in his pleated garments, a sense of freedom unfolds once they flow around the living body. This study positions the fluid and dynamic nature of the fold and its unique relationship with the body at the forefront, exploring the implications of dress for lived experience, which have hitherto taken up little space within academia. It aims to tackle this by bridging history, theory, and practice. Drawing on theoretical concepts by Merleau-Ponty and Deleuze, it investigates the affective dimension of Issey Miyake's pleat. Complementing this discussion with qualitative interviews, it explores how the fold's theoretical significance may translate into reality and what impact it has on bodily sensations, perceptions, and comportment through the world. In extension, this thesis takes into consideration how the fold in fashion may transform the body it drapes, and seeks to identify its potential for a transgression of boundaries.

Keywords

The Fold, Phenomenology, Issey Miyake, Pleats, Deleuze, Merleau-Ponty, Becoming

Acknowledgements

I want to express my deepest gratitude to everyone who has supported me throughout the process of writing this thesis.

Thank you to my peers for creating such a compassionate and supportive environment where I could feel safe and confident to share my work with you. I appreciate all the comments and feedback you've given me.

Thank you to my family and friends who rooted for me during this time and offered me so much emotional support.

Thank you to all my interview partners. I greatly appreciate that you've been so willing to give me your time and trust. Your contribution to this thesis cannot be understated.

Finally, from the bottom of my heart, I want to thank my supervisor Louise Thanem Wallenberg. Your continuous support, feedback, and words of encouragement do not go unnoticed. I am sincerely grateful for all the care, time, and guidance you've given me. It was not only invaluable to my thesis, but it also gave me so much motivation and inspiration.

Preface

A black and white photograph, portraying an arm forcefully reaching into the sky, fingers spread wide apart. The body, which is narrowly framed from the fingertips to the chest, is loosely wrapped in pleated cloth. The numerous folds within the garment dynamically twist, swing, and bend - following the body's lead and flowing with its movement. Right below the armpit, positioned in the space between the contours of the fabric, the name "Issey Miyake" appears. Underneath the bold lettering, three addresses in London, Paris, and Zurich are disclosed, along with their corresponding phone numbers. The image, an advertisement for the *Mercury Pleats* jacket by Issey Miyake, was shot by photographer Irving Penn and published in *Elle* magazine (UK) in 1989.

To me, the image does not merely showcase a person wearing a jacket, but more specifically captures the interplay between a body in movement and the cloth that embraces it. The numerous folds within the garment smoothly flow around the tense and strong arm, creating a symbiosis between soft and hard, fabric and flesh. Additionally, the stiffness and simultaneous fluidity of the pleats create a fascinating tension, giving the garment a delicate and malleable feel whilst also providing it with a certain authority over the body. The folds not only look remarkable, but also embrace the body in a unique manner.

This distinct relationship between human and cloth makes Miyake's pleats so special to me. Whenever my body is enveloped by his folded garments, I notice a shift in how I encounter myself and the world. Frankly, to me, something intrinsically intimate and formative lies within these folds. With this thesis, I aim to unfold the pleat, making their elusive quality tangible and exploring what exactly hides between fold and skin.



Figure 1: Irving Penn for Issey Miyake, 1989.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Introduction **1**

Research Aim and Questions 2

Theoretical Framework 3

Methodology 7

Previous Research 11

Material 17

Outline 17

Chapter One: Unfolding the History of the Pleat **19**

Ancient Egypt 19

Ancient Greece 23

Mariano Fortuny's Delphos Gown 28

Chapter Two: Thinking in Folds **34**

The Fold as a Phenomenological Phenomenon 35

The Enfolding of Self and Garment 40

The Kimono, Flatness, and *Ma* 47

Chapter Three: Folded Experiences **52**

My Interview Partners 54

Findings 55

Folded Aesthetic 55

Feeling the Fold 58

Pleated Perceptions 60

Discussion 64

Conclusion **70**

Bibliography **72**

Introduction

"For over forty years, Miyake has reinvented form, redefined the boundaries of clothing in both functional and aesthetic contexts, and rejuvenated new modern methods of clothing production."[1] The Japanese designer Issey Miyake emerged in the fashion landscape in the 1970s and modernized the wardrobe of the contemporary woman, comprised of simplistic, practical, and versatile garments.[2] More notably, the pleat became a key feature in his implementation of functional and innovative fashion. The *Pleats Please* line, which was launched in 1993, offered an innovative approach to pleating, enabled by the development of new techniques for fabric manipulation as well as the utilization of advanced synthetic fabrics.[3] This "plastic principle" culminated in lightweight and washable clothing that allowed for unrestricted movement.[4]

Shifting the perspective exclusively to Miyake's pleat in relation to the body it drapes, it undeniably enters a unique relationship with its respective wearer. The designer's distinctive vision of creating garments that "have to be seen on the outside as well as felt on the inside", bestowed his fashion designs with an additional layer of purpose, exceeding the merely representational dimension of fashion by integrating the embodied experience of dress.[5] In the words of fashion journalist Suzy Menkes, "the surprise from Issey Miyake was the sense of clothes that moved with the body. […] The Issey Miyake concept was to FREE the body – perpetual movement inside the cloth".[6] Thus, beyond his highly technological approach to fashion, Miyake's design ethos is also interlaced with an understanding of clothing as not only veiling the body, but also facilitating its comportment through space. The material makeup of the clothes, such as

---

[1] Bonnie English, *Japanese Fashion Designers: The Work and Influence of Issey Miyake, Yohji Yamamoto and Rei Kawakubo* (New York: Berg Publishers, 2011), 10.
[2] Bradley Quinn, *Techno Fashion* (Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2002), 150.
[3] English, *Japanese Fashion Designers: The Work and Influence of Issey Miyake, Yohji Yamamoto and Rei Kawakubo* (New York: Berg Publishers, 2011), 10f.
[4] Midori Kitamura, ed., *Issey Miyake* (Cologne: Taschen, 2024), 153.
[5] Jay Cocks, "Living: The Man Who's Changing Clothes," TIME, October 21, 1985, https://time.com/archive/6705023/living-the-man-whos-changing-clothes/.
[6] Madeleine Rothery, "Four Women on Why They Love Wearing Issey Miyake's Easygoing Designs", AnOther, 19 April 2024, https://www.anothermag.com/fashion-beauty/15580/issey-miyake-taschen-book-pleats-please-wearers-laila-gohar-suzy-menkes.

the fabric, construction, and texture, allows the garment to follow the body's silhouette and movement, rather than imposing restrictions or limitations.

Even after his death in 2022, Miyake's legacy carries on, as his distinct conceptualization of fashion continues to be celebrated. His designs were grounded in the appreciation of nature and the human body, yet concurrently infused with an experimental, artistic, and innovative vision. They challenged the dualisms of art and fashion; standardization and individuality; East and West; the organic and the artificial; as well as innovation and tradition.[7] The transgressive quality of his garments becomes particularly evident in the pleat, with the "fold" both physically and metaphorically creating a space that lies between rigid borders. This merging of dichotomies is further illustrated in Natalie Hughes' article on Miyake's *Pleats Please* line: "It's beautiful but it's hardy. It's special but it's democratic. It has a wonderfully anonymous quality, while remaining identifiable to those in the know – or rather, in the *fold*."[8]

Research Aim and Questions

This thesis aims to "unfold" Miyake's pleated garments, investigating the dynamics that lie in the space between body and fold. Through a phenomenological lens, I conceptualize the fold as a lived and embodied phenomenon, one that intrinsically affects human perception, emotions, and movement through space. The exploration of Miyake's pleat will be guided by the following research questions: 1) How do Issey Miyake's pleated garments affect the wearer's lived experience, bodily practices, and conceptions of self?; 2) How do different iterations of the pleat impact the relationship between the body and the fold?; and 3) What lies in the space between fold and flesh? Does it hold transformative, or even transgressive, power?

In order to answer these questions, my research will combine a theoretical and phenomenological approach. I will explore Miyake's pleat from a historical perspective, investigating its construction techniques and relationship with the body throughout time.

---

[7] Christopher Breward, *Fashion* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003), 97; English, *Japanese Fashion Designers*, 10; Djurdja Bartlett, "Issey Miyake: Making Things," in *Fashion Theory* vol. 4, no. 2 (May 2000): 224.

[8] Natalie Hughes, "The History of the Hero: Pleats Please Issey Miyake 30 Years on, Our Appreciation of the Designer's Iconic Pleats Shows No Sign of Waning," *Harpers Bazaar*, August 16, 2023, https://www.harpersbazaar.com/uk/fashion/a44827008/pleats-please-issey-miyake/.

Furthermore, I will place it in a dialogue with theory and interrogate its implications for bodily experience. My theoretical contemplation, fundamentally drawing from Gilles Deleuze's concept of the fold, is enriched by the inclusion of lived experiences. Through this multifaceted analysis, this thesis bridges the historical, the philosophical, and the embodied, moving beyond a rigid understanding of the pleat and the human body.

Theoretical Framework

For this study, I will turn to the theorists Maurice Merleau-Ponty and Gilles Deleuze. In the following, their theoretical concepts will be elaborated and their relevance to this study demonstrated. Through their lens, I will be able to read and understand the fold in fashion as an embodied phenomenon, one that interacts with the body it drapes, constituting a dynamic and transformative process that can invoke a *becoming*.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's Phenomenology

For the analysis of the fold, its impact on the wearer as well as its historical and theoretical significance, I will rely on Merleau-Ponty's conception of phenomenology. This theoretical framework is not only crucial for the investigation of the research topic, but it will also underpin the research methods themselves. In Merleau-Ponty's understanding of phenomenology, the body is the source of human consciousness. Here, mind and body are interconnected, with the body being an active agent that acts as the medium through which we conceive, interact, and know the external world. Just as the body enables us to encounter the world, it is also the vehicle for being perceived and "seen". The body does not merely exist within a spatial and temporal context, but it *inhabits* it, thus also being embedded and shaped by it.[9] Therefore, bodily comportment does not only transpire within a certain time and space, but external situations and phenomena also impose themselves on our corporeal experience. This means that "haptic awareness of ourselves both shapes and is mediated by the situations we

[9] Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *The Primacy of Perception: And Other Essays on Phenomenological Psychology, the Philosophy of Art, History and Politics*, ed. James M. Edie (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1964), 5.

encounter".[10] From this perspective, the human body carries agency and stands in a reciprocal relationship with its surroundings. Because it is engaged in a continuous dialogue with the world, Merleau-Ponty stresses that the body understands the world outside of representations, thus exceeding a symbolic or objectifying function.[11]

When applying this framework to fashion and more specifically pleated garments, clothing becomes a crucial element for our corporeal experience. It impacts haptic experience as well as how one moves through the world and interacts with it. Fundamentally, our "being" in the world is shaped by the clothes that envelop our bodies. Acting as "prosthetic extensions of the body", they play a significant role in our sensual experience and bodily demeanor.[12] With garments being an object of the external world, the body and the cloth enter a symbiotic relationship, as both entities engage and react to each other. In the case of Miyake's designs and his "folded" styles, this dynamic becomes especially overt. His pleated garments are completed once they are filled by a human body. Only then do they become adaptive, three-dimensional pieces of cloth that respond to the body's shape and movement.[13] In this context, Miyake's employment of synthetic fabrics and the folded structure of the pleats allow the cloth to expand or contract according to the body's movement in the world. Hence, the space between the skin and the fold is fluid and malleable – flowing and moving with its wearer.[14]

In regard to Issey Miyake's pleats, one may argue that his designs inherently involve a phenomenological approach, since they purposefully address the relationship between body and garment. How the body moves, interacts, and experiences the world is also partially shaped by the garment in which it is draped. In the case of Miyake, the body can move through the world in a less restricted manner, with the pleat "folding" in and out accordingly. With this dynamic at hand, I believe it is long overdue to study precisely this embodied phenomenon of wearing pleats. However, there is an identifiable deficit in Merleau-Ponty's theory, since he fails to acknowledge the significance of

---

[10] Llewellyn Negrin, "Maurice Merleau-Ponty: The Corporeal Experience of Fashion," in *Thinking Through Fashion: A Guide to Key Theorists*, eds. Agnès Rocamora and Anneke Smelik (London: I.B. Tauris, 2019), 119.
[11] Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception* (London: Routledge, 2010), 141.
[12] Negrin, "Maurice Merleau-Ponty," 122.
[13] Ibid., 126.
[14] Ibid., 127.

gender for lived experiences. Amongst scholars such as Judith Butler, Luce Irigaray, Iris Young, or Elizabeth Grosz, Joanne Entwistle points out Merleau-Ponty's disregard for how gender identity impacts bodily comportment through space, as well as bodily awareness and perception.[15] Above being spatial and temporal beings, we are also gendered beings. A certain gender affiliation, or lack thereof, inevitably affects not only sartorial practices and the presentation of the self but also how one encounters and is encountered in the world.[16] I align with the feminist call to include gender in the phenomenological debate and will correspondingly include it in my analysis.

Gilles Deleuze's "Fold"

Deleuze's book *The Fold: Leibniz and the Baroque* is a philosophical encounter with the Baroque through the concept of the "fold". Drawing on Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz's writings, Deleuze explores the fold in connection to science, history, various forms of art, architecture, and mathematics.[17] He separates the fold into two distinct, yet interconnected entities, *the pleats of matter* and *the folds of the soul*. The former conception of the fold refers to its material presence, as manifested in Baroque architecture, drapery, or nature. The latter categorization touches upon the fold as an immaterial phenomenon, which exists in the realm of the soul.[18] As an allegorical explanation, Deleuze introduces the *Baroque House*, which consists of two levels. The lower floor, equipped with common rooms and windows that act as openings to external

[15] Phenomenology has found its footing in feminist scholarship. See Judith Butler, "Sexual Difference as a Question of Ethics: Alterities of the Flesh in Irigaray and Merleau-Ponty," in *Senses of the Subject* (New York, USA: Fordham University Press, 2015), 149–70; Butler, "Performative Acts and Gender Constitution: An Essay in Phenomenology and Feminist Theory," in *Theatre Journal* vol. 40, no. 4 (1988): 519–31; Butler, "Sexual Ideology and Phenomenological Description: A Feminist Critique of Merleau-Ponty's Phenomenology of Perception," in *The Thinking Muse: Feminism and Modern French Philosophy*, eds. Jeffner Allen and Marion Young (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1989), 85–100; Luce Irigaray, *An Ethics of Sexual Difference* (London: Athlone, 1993); Iris Marion Young, *On Female Body Experience: Throwing Like a Girl and Other Essays* (Oxford, USA: Oxford University Press, Incorporated, 2005); Mel Y. Chen, *Animacies: Biopolitics, Racial Mattering, and Queer Affect* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2012).

[16] Entwistle, *The Fashioned Body: Fashion, Dress and Modern Social Theory* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2023), 29.

[17] Gilles Deleuze, *The Fold: Leibniz and the Baroque* (London: Continuum International Publishing Group, 2006). Translator's foreword.

[18] Ibid., 3f.

influences, is filled with “masses and organisms”.[19] When ascending to the upper floor, we encounter a dark, windowless room that houses the canvas of the soul. Its surface is marked by “folds, cords or springs [that] represent an innate form of knowledge, but when solicited by matter they move into action”.[20] The two floors correspond with each other, with the physical matter from below continuously folding into the inner dimension of the self on the upper floor. When placing this abstract model of the fold into the frame of lived reality, Deleuze uses the fold as a framework to understand how body and mind relate to each other. He deems the fold a dynamic and transformative force that incites an enmeshing of outside and inside/matter and soul.[21]

Embedding fashion in the concept of the fold, one can conceptualize the fold quite literally, as it also manifests itself in the physical world as a tangible, material phenomenon. A closer look at Deleuze’s illustration of the fold’s physical presence in Baroque paintings, architecture, or sculpture, grants us a better understanding of how the fold functions as *pleats of matter*. For Deleuze, the fold is an infinite force that affects physical matter, transforming it into new forms.[22] In relation to clothing, Deleuze states the following: “In every instance folds of clothing acquire an autonomy and a fullness *that are not simply decorative effects*. They convey the intensity of a spiritual force exerted on the body, […] in every event to turn it inside out and to mold its inner surfaces”.[23] The relevance of the Baroque is once again highlighted when Deleuze takes Baroque dress as an example for the autonomous quality of the fold. He points to its distinctive construction, which allows the fabric and its endless folds to exist independently from the body it covers. The entrapment of air between body and fabric, as well as between fabric and fabric, not only grants the physical fold a certain agency, but also allows it to interact with the body in a dynamic and transformative manner.[24] In transgressing its subordinate role to the body, the fold frees itself from the restrictions imposed by the materiality of the body it drapes.

---

[19] Ibid., 11.
[20] Ibid., 4.
[21] I use the term “transformative“ to describe how the fold can establish a significant change in bodily practices, self-consciousness, and in a more general sense, one‘s lived experience in the world.
[22] Deleuze, *The Fold*, 39.
[23] Ibid., 140.
[24] Ibid., 139.

Exploring Issey Miyake's pleat along this theoretical framework enables a deep and meaningful analysis of the pleat's significance for bodily experience, human existence, and even illuminates the possibility for a transgression of binaries. In combination with Merleau-Ponty, as well as interviews which allow for an investigation of the fold as a lived phenomenon, this thesis intends to marry theory with practice.

Methodology

For the study of the relationship between the fold and the body in Miyake's fashion, I will employ a multi-methodological approach. Firstly, by adopting a phenomenological perspective, my research will examine the embodied experience of wearing pleated garments. Combined with a theoretical analysis, which is guided by the thinkers Merleau-Ponty and Deleuze, I will investigate the fold as both an abstract and lived phenomenon. Thus, theory and "practice" are engaged in a dialectical relationship, with empirical findings feeding into theory and vice versa. Nonetheless, my study primarily follows a deductive approach, as it will depart from a theoretical analysis, comprised of a historical and a philosophical investigation of the pleat, followed up by an exploration of the lived experience of wearing Miyake's pleats.[25] In this case, the "theoretical formulations effectively precede the data-gathering with the latter functioning as proof or 'falsification' of the original supposition, hypothesis, or general theory".[26]

This strategy concurrently enables me to "unfold" the pleat and uncover what lies in the space within. I understand this "unfolding" as both a felt sensation and a metaphor. On one hand, the fold contracts and expands according to the bodily movements of the wearer, frequently folding in and out. Once the pleated garment is wrapped around the human body, its pleats "unfold" according to their wearer's particular body shape and comportment through space. On the other hand, I will carry out a symbolic "unfolding" by critically investigating the interaction between the pleat and the human body – aiming

[25] This thesis employs the term "pleat" more poignantly in the context of fashion, since it refers to the deliberate, fixed, and repetitive folding of fabric. In contrast, "fold" encompasses a wider range of configurations, as it can come to life in either a spontaneous or an intentional manner and can be understood as both a physical or a metaphysical concept. Hence, "pleat" directly refers to form and texture, whereas "fold" is used more fluidly.

[26] Marianne Franklin, *Understanding Research: Coping with the Quantitative - Qualitative Divide* (New York: Routledge, 2012), 233.

to provide insight into the bodily implications of the fold. Although this theoretical "unfolding" will be carried out along Deleuze's train of thought, I will also introduce other relevant theorists and concepts, if called for.

The theoretical analysis builds a rich framework for the subsequent interrogation of embodied experience. By infusing my research with a phenomenological perspective, I am able to bridge the theoretical with the subjective. Through this, I intend to render the human body draped in pleats as both an object and a subject in my research. In relation to Entwistle's call to study dress as "situated bodily practice", I find this approach particularly fruitful, as it not only offers insight into how bodily and sartorial practices intersect, but also considers the impact of culture in shaping these practices.[27] In contrast, a merely intellectual study of dressed bodies dismisses the body as an active agent and neglects the emotional, sensory, and embodied dimensions of dressing. Here, the "meaning of dressing practices […] [is] transferred *onto* the dressed body from outside".[28] Commonly within fashion studies, dressed bodies are conceived as representational entities, reflecting certain social, cultural, or political phenomena. Although this approach to studying fashion offers grounds for a meaningful analysis of the cultural significance and semiotic value of clothing, it fails to acknowledge the significance of dress in impacting the body as an "active and perceptive vehicle of being".[29] Expanding on this, Stephen Seely calls for an investigation of the transformative potential of fashion, since he believes that fashion holds power beyond the aesthetic realm. Cloth and flesh interact and connect with each other, entering a symbiotic relationship – or in his words, they engage in a process of *assemblage*.[30] Consequently, the encounter between garment and body enables a transformation and a reconfiguration of the body.[31] Moreover, it can become a political tool, as it "has the

---

[27] Entwistle, "The Dressed Body," in *Body Dressing: Dress, Body, Culture*, eds. Joanne Entwistle and Elizabeth Wilson (Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2001), 34.
[28] Lucia Ruggerone, "The Feeling of Being Dressed: Affect Studies and the Clothed Body," in *Fashion Theory* vol. 21, no. 5 (3 September 2017): 579.
[29] Andrea Eckersley and Cameron Duff, "Bodies of Fashion and the Fashioning of Subjectivity," in *Body & Society* vol. 26, no. 4 (December 2020): 39f; Entwistle, "Fashion and the Fleshy Body: Dress as Embodied Practice," in *Fashion Theory* vol. 4, no. 3 (August 2000): 335.
[30] This concept is borrowed from Deleuze and Guattari, who define *assemblage* as a dynamic and fluid composition of heterogeneous elements (bodies, matters, forces, etc.) to form a whole.
[31] Stephen D. Seely, "How Do You Dress a Body Without Organs?: Affective Fashion and Nonhuman Becoming," in *WSQ: Women's Studies Quarterly* vol. 41, no. 1–2 (March 2013): 248ff.

power to deterritorialize bodies from certain dominant modes of stratification", thus challenging hegemonic conventions and rigid binaries.[32] The transgressive element of fashion is rooted in its ability to morph with the body, creating a body in transformation that can break out of the heteronormative and patriarchal structures it is embedded in.

I will adapt this line of thought to my study of Miyake's pleat since it allows me to read it with respect to its transgressive potential. This critical view on fashion, along with engaging it in a dialogue with relevant theory, enables us to "untangle our research problems by infusing new sensations, extracting hidden emissions and creating unconventional insights from the empirical material at hand".[33] Consequently, this can bring forth a questioning of the norms and ideologies embedded in the phenomenon of the pleat. In essence, the interrogation of the pleat through a broader socio-cultural lens, combined with the objective to reveal its capacities for liberation and emancipation, has the potential to render academic research politically powerful.

Embodied Research

Within academia, the phenomenological study of embodied, subjective experiences has been met with skepticism regarding its scientific value, with questions centered towards the reliability, validity, and trustworthiness of the results.[34] Indeed, individual and subjective accounts cannot be replicated nor verified or falsified. One may never apply the results of a phenomenological study on a broader scale, as they are not generalizable and rely on interpretative analyses.[35] Nonetheless, the generation of subjective knowledge in an academic context offers valuable and profound insights into human reality – how individuals think, experience, feel, and move through the world. In the same breath, the phenomenological perspective embraces the researcher's involvement in the research process. By acknowledging their inevitable influence on the data

[32] Ibid., 263.
[33] Torkild Thanem and David Knights, *Embodied Research Methods* (London: SAGE, 2019), 117.
[34] These criticisms stem particularly from the positivist tradition, which stands in contrast to the phenomenological approach. As the dominant paradigm in academia, it is based on the premise that science should generate objective knowledge. The results of scientific research are expected to be universally applicable and replicable.
[35] See Kerry E. Howell, "Reliability, Generalisation and Reflexivity: Identifying Validity and Trustworthiness," in *An Introduction to the Philosophy of Methodology* (Los Angeles: SAGE, 2016), 182–92.

collection and the subsequent analysis and interpretation of the results, the researcher develops a self-reflective and discerning eye, allowing them to address potential biases and engage with their material in a more transparent manner.

Semi-Structured Interviews

The method of semi-structured interviews will aid me in discovering how Miyake's pleats are experienced by individuals. By allowing a range of different voices to be heard, I can generate a richer and more thorough study. My embodied participation in the interviews will also be of significance, as I plan to engage in a natural dialogue with my interview partners rather than a strict question-and-answer exchange. Pre-determined questions will lead the direction of the interviews, although the discussion is allowed to flow freely. A balance between structure and spontaneity gives room to explore aspects that are specifically important to the individual or that I may not have considered before.[36] Since the topic of interest addresses an intimate part of human experience, namely the sensual and emotional feelings of one's body enveloped in pleats, I want to create a comfortable space for my research partners to express their perspectives. By being vulnerable and honest in sharing my own experiences, I intend to foster a sense of trust and safety. A considerate and empathetic approach towards the interview partners and their personal stories before, during, and after the interview is necessary for ethical interview practice, which will factor into my research process.[37]

The eight interview partners I will be interviewing are primarily sourced through social media, as different platforms allow me to find a wider range of wearers of Issey Miyake. I will seek out my interview partners on the platforms *Instagram* and *TikTok*. The search will come about by searching for posts that are tagged with relevant hashtags such as #isseymiyake, #pleatsplease, or #hommeplissé, for example. In addition, I will search through the tagged posts of the Instagram accounts @isseymiyakeofficial, @pleatspleaseisseymiyake, and @hommeplisse_isseymiyake. This strategy enables me to message people who actively wear, or have previously worn Miyake's pleats. Nearly all of my interviews are going to be conducted online through *Zoom* or *Google Meet*.

[36] Howell, *An Introduction to the Philosophy of Methodology*, 199.
[37] Thanem and Knights, *Embodied Research Methods*, 90.

Since interviews are "affective and embodied encounters between people", it would have been of great advantage to meet all of my interview partners in person.[38] However, due to geographical distances, this is not feasible. Fortunately, I will be able to meet with one participant personally, which allows for an unmediated interview setting. Reflecting on the impact of my embodied participation as the researcher, it is to be noted that my involvement in the interviews may influence my partners' responses. In addition, I deem it valuable to infuse the interviews with questions relating to the results of prior ones, if they offer space for it. This "process of inductive open discovery" makes it possible for me to collect various perspectives on specific topics, enabling a more thorough investigation of the topic.[39] In reference to Sarah J. Tracy, who stresses that interviews are comprised of an interactive process where meaning is equally created between the participants, I will conduct my interviews in a similar manner.[40] By approaching the interview setting from a "mutual discovery" approach, it invites both my partners and me to share and reflect on our experiences and to create meaning "together".[41]

The information derived from the interviews is invaluable for discovering the phenomenal implications of the pleat. As the next section will demonstrate, the inclusion of the lived experience of wearing Issey Miyake's pleats, or pleated garments in general for that matter, has previously been missing in the academic landscape.

Previous Research

On Issey Miyake and Japanese Avant-Garde Fashion

Within academia, Issey Miyake has predominantly been documented in light of his impact on the "Japanese Avant-Garde" that emerged at the end of the 20th century. Together with designers Rei Kawakubo and Yohji Yamamoto, the trio introduced a new "wave" of fashion to the West, offering a fresh perspective on fashion that disrupted the fashion system in Europe at the time. By incorporating asymmetrical designs, loose silhouettes, and monochromatic color palettes into their collections, they challenged

[38] Ibid., 91.
[39] Howell, *An Introduction to the Philosophy of Methodology*, 200.
[40] Sarah J. Tracy, *Qualitative Research Methods: Collecting Evidence, Crafting Analysis, Communicating Impact* (London: Wiley-Blackwell, 2013), 132.
[41] Ibid.

dominant fashion conventions.[42] Notably, scholars Yuniya Kawamura, Bradley Quinn, and Flavia Loscalpio point out this subsequent amalgamation of the different designers and highlight the problem that lies within condensing their unique aesthetic visions into the umbrella term of "Japanese" fashion.[43] Although the collections by Miyake, Kawakubo, and Yamamoto reflect a stark contrast that existed between Eastern and Western conceptions of fashion during this era, their design philosophies and aesthetic languages deserve to be studied individually. Not only did the designers themselves reject a classification based on their ethnicity as "Japanese", but this blunt reduction also does a disservice to their unique contributions to fashion. Furthermore, it reproduces a Eurocentric perspective, by marking them as "other" against the Western fashion landscape. In agreement with Patricia Mears' critique of their categorization under "Japanese" fashion, it is "both uninformed and inaccurate" as well as rooted in racism and a refusal to understand and acknowledge the complexity of their designs.[44]

Nonetheless, beyond their cultural background, certain parallels can be drawn in regard to their aesthetics, technical approaches, and concepts.[45] Hence, multiple studies have analyzed the designers' marks on fashion with respect to various theoretical frameworks. More commonly, this triad of designers has been tied to Jacques Derrida's concept of *deconstruction.*[46] Their deconstructionist aesthetic, characterized by an "unfinished" and frayed look, dark colors, and obscured forms, went against the polished and refined styles in Paris of the 1970s and 1980s.[47] Although Rei Kawakubo and Yohji Yamamoto take center stage in the deconstructionist readings of "Japanese" fashion

---

[42] See Yuniya Kawamura, *The Japanese Revolution in Paris Fashion* (Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2004); Melissa Marra-Alvarez, "When the West Wore East: Rei Kawakubo, Yohji Yamamoto and The Rise of the Japanese Avant-Garde in Fashion," in *Kyoto Costume Institute* vol. 57 (2010); Flavia Loscialpo, "The Fashion Revolution of Avant-Garde Japanese Designers: Issey Miyake, Rei Kawakubo, Yohji Yamamoto," in *Fashion-Wise*, eds. Maria Vaccarella and Jacquelyn Foltyn (Leiden: BRILL, 2013), 21–32.

[43] Kawamura, *The Japanese Revolution in Paris Fashion*, 125; Quinn, *Techno Fashion*, 141; Loscialpo, "The Fashion Revolution of Avant-Garde Japanese Designers," 23.

[44] Patricia Mears, "Formalism and Revolution: Rei Kawakubo and Yohji Yamamoto," in *Japan Fashion Now*, ed. Valerie Steele (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2010), 155.

[45] Quinn, *Techno Fashion*, 142.

[46] Deconstruction aims to challenge normative constructs, destabilizing established modes of thought, practices and meanings. In the context of fashion, deconstruction disrupts traditional forms and design elements through the means of exposing, reworking or fragmenting.

[47] Mears, "Formalism and Revolution", 181.

design, Issey Miyake is continuously thrown into the mix.[48] In contrast to Miyake, Kawakubo and Yamamoto represented more of an "impoverished aesthetic" that played with garment construction and imperfection.[49] However, Miyake aligned with their deconstructionist vision in terms of applying cutting-edge technology and reconfiguring the relationship between cloth and body by introducing 'flat' and shapeless silhouettes that contrasted the highly tailored fashion in the West.[50] This approach to fashion called into question ideas of "symmetry, the idea of perfection, a mimetic relationship between the garment and the body, and the eroticisation of femininity", thus rendering it deconstructive in light of the dominant fashion mode at the time.[51]

This thesis will delve deeper into Issey Miyake's work as a fashion designer, beyond his role as a constituting figure of the Japanese Avant-Garde. It focuses on the utilization of the pleat in his designs, as well as their deeper significance for embodied experience. This is achieved by situating the pleat in a historical and theoretical framework. The previous research relevant to this endeavor will be discussed below.

On Pleats and the "Fold"

A wide range of academic encounters with the pleat derive from archaeological, historical, as well as design-based fields. Various scholars and articles have investigated the pleat as a phenomenon either within a certain era or traced its evolution throughout history. In this context, the starting point for the exploration of the pleat lies in Ancient Egypt. Nonetheless, studies on pleated dress are more commonly rooted in Ancient Greece, specifically in regard to the Greek sculptures that depict bodies characteristically draped in "folded" cloth. Thus, both Ancient Egypt and Ancient Greece are significant when considering the origins of the pleat.[52] Moving forward in

---

[48] English, *Japanese Fashion Designers*; Loscialpo, "Fashion and Philosophical Deconstruction: A Fashion In-Deconstruction," in *Fashion Forward*, eds. Alissa De Wit-Paul and Mira Crouch (Oxford: BRILL, 2011), 13–27; Mears, "Formalism and Revolution".

[49] English, "Sartorial Deconstruction: The Nature of Conceptualism in Postmodernist Japanese Fashion Design", in *The International Journal of the Humanities: Annual Review* vol. 9, no. 2 (2011): 83.

[50] Susannah Frankel, "Flatness," in *Future Beauty: 30 Years of Japanese Fashion*, ed. Akiko Fukai (London: Merrell, 2010), 64.

[51] Loscialpo, "The Fashion Revolution of Avant-Garde Japanese Designers," 24.

[52] On the Pleat in Ancient Egypt, see Slawomir Rzepka, "Reconstruction of the Kilt Represented on a Statue of Neferefre," in *The Journal of Egyptian Archealogy* 86 (2000); Jana Jones, "The Enigma of the Pleated Dress: New Insights from Early Dynastic Helwan Reliefs," in *The Journal of Egyptian*

time, Mariano Fortuny is crystallized as a key figure in the history of the pleat. Heavily inspired by classical Greek dress, Fortuny created the infamous *Delphos* dress in 1907, which offered a less restrictive alternative to the tight-fitted and corseted women's fashion at the time.[53] Beyond the significance of the pleat in introducing a "liberated" style of dress to Western fashion, the techniques behind its creation have remained a mystery. However, some scholars have made it their mission to reconstruct and uncover the lost knowledge of Fortuny's techniques for fabric manipulation.[54]

Expanding on the practical application of the fold, it has also been recognized for its ability to offer a distinct mode of thought in relation to design, architecture, and fashion. Hence, the fold acts as a theoretical framework beyond the physical dimension. The act of folding in and out, as well as "unfolding" the pleat is, both in the literal and symbolic sense, a dynamic process. Scholars have tied this to Deleuze's conception of the fold. Through this lens, the pleat is always in a transitional and fluid state, continuously oscillating between, for example, inside and outside or depth and surface, thus constituting its own logic.

For example, the pleat and its implementation as a design strategy in architecture is laid out by Marta Muñoz and Ángel Cordero in their article "The Fold as a Design Strategy: Analogy between Architecture and Issey Miyake's Work", where they draw

---

Archaeology vol. 100, no. 1 (January 2014): 209–31. On the Pleat in Ancient Greece, see Karina Grömer and Antoinette Rast-Eicher, "To Pleat or Not to Pleat – An Early History of Creating Three-Dimensional Linear Textile Structures," in *Annalen Des Naturhistorischen Museums in Wien* vol. 121 (2019): 83–112; Linda Welters et al., "Ptychoseis = Folds + Pleats: Drapery from Ancient Greek Dress to 2lst-Century Fashion," in *Dress* vol. 31, no. 1 (January 2004): 72–77. On the Pleat in Ancient Greece, see Jing Chen and Yiqiang Cao, "Research on the Drapery in Ancient Greek Sculptures," in *Asian Social Science* 17, no. 6 (May 31, 2021): 29–37; Stella Spantidaki, "The Embellishment Techniques of Classical Greek Textiles," in *Greek and Roman Textiles and Dress: An Interdisciplinary Anthology*, ed. Mary Harlow and Marie-Louise Nosch (Oxford: Oxbow Books, 2014), 34–45; Christina Riggs, *Unwrapping Ancient Egypt: The Shroud, The Secret and The Sacred* (London: Bloomsbury Academic, 2014); Janet M. Johnstone, "Wrapping and Tying Ancient Egyptian New Kingdom Dresses," in *Wrapping and Unwrapping Material Culture*, eds. Susanna Harris and Laurence Douny (London, New York: Routledge, 2016), 59–82.

[53] Brenda Polan and Roger Tredre, *The Great Fashion Designers* (Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2009), 25f.

[54] L. Leann Kanda, "Under Tension, Under Pressure, Making Waves: Reconstructing the Historic Fortuny Delphos Pleats," in *Dress* vol. 50, no. 1 (January 2, 2024): 81–100; Kathleen Kearney, "Mariano Fortuny's Delphos Robe: Some Possible Methods of Pleating and the Permanence of the Pleats," in *Clothing and Textiles Research Journal* vol. 10, no. 3 (March 1992): 86–91; Virginia Farinelli et al., "Unveiling Polychrome Printing Methods on Textiles: Preliminary Results from the Mariano Fortuny y Madrazo Collection in Venice," in *Heritage* vol. 7, no. 3 (March 1, 2024): 1298–1319; Diane Sparks, "Explorations In Pleated Fabric Garment Structures," in *Clothing and Textiles Research Journal* vol. 22, no. 1–2 (2004): 38–43.

on Miyake's folded fashion as a guiding principle for architecture. They identify the dynamic and transformative quality of the fold in connection to Deleuze and translate it into a strategy for the architectural design process. In this regard, the building is conceptualized as an envelope that holds interior space, which, through continuous folding, can be manipulated to accommodate different needs, thus becoming highly adaptable. Additionally, just like the body inhabiting Miyake's garments, the space within is freed from the enclosure of its exterior and can exist independently.[55]

The "architectural" fold is also presented in Giuliana Bruno's article "Pleats of Matter, Folds of the Soul", where she inserts the fold and its manifestation in film, architecture, and fashion, into the landscape of emotions and affects. For her, the fold is expressed in physical matter and moves within the immaterial fabric of one's emotional world. She draws a parallel between Miyake's pleats and architecture, since both are "a construction that is to be inhabited".[56] Consequently, the architectural structure of the fold begins to "host" the soul and the mood of the person that lives in it. Through this, Miyake's pleats shift according to one's mental state, as their "draping motion embodies the motion of an emotion".[57] Put simply, Bruno renders the fold an affective structure, one that absorbs the person it encompasses and vice versa. Due to this, its physical flow, folding between in-and-out, mirrors the intimate inner world of its wearer.

Entering the technical territory of the pleat, textile research has been increasingly devoted to the different ways of "folding" fabric. For example, Paul Jackson has contributed with his book *Complete Pleats*, which outlines a wide spectrum of pleating techniques and innovations in fashion, architecture, and product design.[58]

Coming from the discipline of practical fashion design, Tsai-Chun Huang, whose key research focus lies in the relationship between materials and the body, has developed a textile research methodology based on the principle of the fold. His so-called "pliable logic" "references a malleable, recursive procedure to encourage the researcher to search

---

[55] Marta Muñoz and Ángel Cordero, "The Fold as a Design Strategy: Analogy between Architecture and Issey Miyake's Work," in *Arts* vol. 13, no. 5 (23 September 2024): 144.
[56] Giuliana Bruno, "Pleats of Matter, Folds of the Soul," in *Afterimages of Gilles Deleuze's Film Philosophy*, ed. D. N. Rodowick (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2009), 222.
[57] Ibid., 224.
[58] Jackson Paul, *Complete Pleats: Pleating Techniques for Fashion, Architecture, Design* (London: Laurence King Publishing, 2015).

for meaning in between stages".[59] Comprised of the three premises of "softness", "recursive sequence", and *plica ex plica*, Huang constructs a framework for making and thinking in pleats. I will briefly pinpoint the ideas behind this complex methodology, beginning with "softness". Within a "soft logic", textiles are considered elastic and pliant, moving beyond binaries. Additionally, he brings in the concept of "recursive sequence", which he uses to call on textile researchers to position themselves within a "make-think-write" cycle, allowing them to engage in a dialectic process consisting of practice, self-reflection, and analysis.[60] Finally, Deleuze's notion of *plica ex plica* is integrated in order to emphasize the space in between folds – the movement between binaries – and to further "demonstrate how layers of concept join together for new knowledge".[61] Although the fold guides his methodology, Huang's novel approach to textile research aims to expand beyond the realm of pleating. Within fashion studies, this methodology holds value to some degree, as it calls on the researcher to engage with the object of inquiry and theory in a dialectical and flexible manner. Furthermore, it encourages us to "elaborate the complexity embodied in materiality", rendering physical materials or objects as active constituents of lived reality.[62]

Notably, within fashion studies, Smelik has developed a similar approach. Expanding on the so-called "new materialism", she emphasizes the relevance of materiality within scholarship and calls for a departure from the dualistic understanding of the material and immaterial. By understanding human and non-human entities as "inextricably entangled", this framework is akin to the logic of the fold, in the way that it shifts the focus towards the intersection between binaries.[63] This stance is further exemplified in Smelik's other works on the "fold" and the body. In "Fashioning the Fold: Multiple Becomings", she implements Deleuze's mode of thought in order to

[59] Tsai-Chun Huang, "In-Between Pleats: Pleats, Pleating and 'Pliable Logic'" (Ph.D. Royal College of Art, UK, 2020), 147.
[60] Huang, "Pliable Logic as a Practice-Led Research Methodology for Textile Practice," in *TEXTILE* vol. 22, no. 1 (2 January 2024): 142–57.
[61] Ibid., 155.
[62] Huang, "In-Between Pleats," 268.
[63] Anneke Smelik, "New Materialism: A Theoretical Framework for Fashion in the Age of Technological Innovation," in *International Journal of Fashion Studies* vol. 5, no. 1 (1 April 2018): 33–54.

interrogate the significance of the fold in fashion and its transformative power.[64] She looks beyond the representational sphere of fashion and examines its dynamic and formative dimension, by illustrating how the fold has been implemented in fashion and how it affects the human body. Therefore, her Deleuzian analysis serves as a valuable guide for this thesis. Although she offers some insight into how the designs of the Japanese Avant-Garde correlate with Deleuze's conception of the "fold", her study has been conducted in a purely theoretical and rather condensed manner. This offers me grounds for a much more thorough investigation of the fold in Miyake's designs. Conceptualized as an embodied phenomenon, the pleat demands an investigation that also considers its materiality and impact on bodily experience.

Material

In order to investigate Issey Miyake and the pleat in a multifaceted and thorough way, this thesis will be fed by a range of materials. Beyond engaging with theory, I will also let personal accounts inform my study. With the interaction between garment and body at the forefront of this topic, my research will include the material reality of wearing the pleat. For this, I will conduct interviews with different people who wear, or have worn Issey Miyake's pleated garments. Consequently, my findings will be placed in a wider context, as I will draw connections to other theories to explore elements that demand greater attention. The information drawn from the interviews aims to provide a rich description of how the fold and body connect, interact, and even transform one another. The analysis will narrow the data down to a selected range of interview excerpts I deem particularly interesting. Connections to other theories will be drawn to explore aspects that demand greater attention.

Outline

The study of the fold in Miyake's pleated fashion will be divided into three chapters, each investigating different key themes. This will contribute to creating a multifaceted study that incorporates a historical, theoretical, and empirical angle.

---

[64] Smelik, "Fashioning the Fold: Multiple Becomings," in *This Deleuzian Century: Art, Activism, Life*, eds. Rosi Braidotti and Rick Dolphijn (Leiden and Boston: BRILL, 2014), 37–56.

The first chapter will trace the fold back to its origins. It places Miyake's pleated designs in a broader historical context, beginning in Ancient Egypt. Subsequentially, the drapes of Ancient Greece will be more thoroughly analyzed.[65] The chapter continues its journey into the early 20th century, where Fortuny's *Delphos* dress is closely examined. An interview with a former owner of the gown will allow me to expand on the historical exploration of the *Delphos* gown with a more detailed phenomenological study.

The second chapter delves into the theoretical implications of the fold. It aims to "unfold" the pleat through theory, examining its significance for the human body and lived experience. This chapter theoretically interrogates the fold, primarily assisted by Merleau-Ponty and Deleuze. Moreover, by including the Japanese concept of *ma*, I aim to enrich the theoretical analysis and move beyond a solely Eurocentric study.

For the final chapter of this thesis, I will analyze the results of my qualitative interviews. This step allows me to "test" my theoretical conclusions, as I will complement them with the data from personal accounts by wearers of Miyake's garments. The findings of this study will inform the theory I will subsequently draw on in order to analyze parallels, peculiarities, or other noteworthy aspects found in these narratives.

In the conclusion, I will answer my research questions surrounding the fold's impact on the body and whether it holds transformative or even transgressive power. The approach employed for this study is not novel, yet has also not found a real footing in fashion studies thus far. The close investigation of a particular texture in clothing; conceptualized under a rich theoretical framework and combined with a study of its effects on embodied experience, can give seemingly trivial aspects of clothing their deserved scholarly attention as well as widen the scope of phenomenological research topics in the field of fashion.

[65] To keep this chapter at a reasonable length, I will omit the periods of the Roman and Medieval Ages, the Renaissance, and the Baroque.

Chapter One: Unfolding the History of the Pleat

In this chapter, I will trace the pleat back in history, looking at how its different iterations affect the relationship between the fold and the human body. This historical contextualization enables an all-encompassing exploration of the pleat, fostering a deeper understanding of the pleat's functional, aesthetic, and symbolic utilization throughout time. I will also highlight how various construction techniques and materials have not only impacted the way it holds, veils, or accentuates the body, but moreover, how it interacts with it.

Ancient Egypt

When unfolding the pleat's historical dimension, we may leap as far back as Ancient Egypt. Not only do historical artifacts, such as recovered frescoes, reliefs, or statues reveal the existence of Ancient clothing with pleated textures, but additionally, various preserved garments further attest to the utilization of the fold in garment construction.[66] Throughout Egypt's history, linen garments such as tunics, kilts, and wrap-around dresses were pleated, tracing back to around 2800 B.C.E., in the period of the First Dynasty.[67] Remarkably, archaeological findings suggest a minimal change in dress styles over the period of nearly three thousand years.[68] However, entering the New Kingdom in Egypt, which dated from the sixteenth to the fourteenth century B.C.E., the wardrobe of the upper class copiously integrated pleated, folded, layered, and draped styles. The sartorial codes of that era were much more complex and elaborate compared to earlier periods.[69] This sophisticated attire was presumably not worn on a daily basis but instead, reserved for ceremonial events, both "in life or for eternity and the next life".[70] Hence, pleated dress was not only intended to clothe living bodies, but

---

[66] Grömer and Rast-Eicher, "To Pleat or Not to Pleat," 89; Terese Zaki, Ahmed Negm Eldin, and Ghada Alkholy, "Innovation of Women Garment Designs through Employing Geometrical Pleats Fixed by Heat Setting," in مجلة العمارة و الفنون و العلوم الإنسانية vol. 8, no. 39 (2023): 638.
[67] Liza Cleland, Glenys Davies, and Lloyd Llewellyn-Jones, *Greek and Roman Dress from A to Z* (London: Routledge, 2007), 55; Grömer and Rast-Eicher, "To Pleat or Not to Pleat," 89.
[68] James Laver, *Costume and Fashion: A Concise History* (New York: Thames & Hudson Inc., 2020), 18.
[69] Johnstone, "Wrapping and Tying Ancient Egyptian New Kingdom Dresses," 59.
[70] William H. Peck, *The Material World of Ancient Egypt* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013), 57f.

additionally, it was a valuable offering for the dead, considered "desirable funerary equipment".[71]

When it comes to the construction of these styles, the pleat was not just a pleat. The finer and more complex its fold, the higher one's social rank.[72] Thus, elaborate pleats represented wealth and were designated for the elite. This may very well be due to the nature of their production since it entailed a considerable amount of work and additional costs. For example, when considering the fabric that was needed, pleat production could require double the quantity of cloth as compared to unpleated garments.[73] Nonetheless, the exact techniques behind creating Egyptian pleats remains uncertain, and scholars have offered various explanations of how the fold could have been formed and solidified in the textile.[74] For example, it is assumed that the linen cloth was manipulated once it was in a damp condition, or by weaving it and varying between loose and tight warps.[75] Additionally, practices such as freehand "pinching", "pressing", re-pleating, and crimpling are presumed to have aided in the making and the preservation of folded textures.[76] Pleating could have also been enabled by the means of using a board with parallel ridges cut onto its surface, or by utilizing hot stones to pleat starched fabrics.[77] For a more permanent fixation of the pleat, chemical compounds or stiffening agents might also have been of help.[78]

Given this background, one underlying question remains: namely how Ancient pleats affected the living bodies it draped. In their study on Ancient Egyptian dance, Jordan Galczynsky, a Ph.D. candidate who specializes in ancient Egyptian material culture, and Robyn Price, a doctor of archeology whose research focus lies in ancient sensory experience, discuss the significance of linen for bodily movement. Here, they identify its qualities of being lightweight, non-irritating, and cool. However, once it is layered and wrapped around the body, it transforms from a light textile into a rather firm

---

[71] Jones, "The Enigma of the Pleated Dress," 230.
[72] Johnstone, "Wrapping and Tying Ancient Egyptian New Kingdom Dresses," 59; Cleland, Davies, and Llewellyn-Jones, *Greek and Roman Dress from A to Z*, 55.
[73] Riggs, *Unwrapping Ancient Egypt*, 118f.
[74] Zaki et al., "Innovation of Women Garment Designs," 638.
[75] Grömer and Rast-Eicher, "To Pleat or Not to Pleat," 89.
[76] Jones, "The Enigma of the Pleated Dress," 223f.
[77] Zaki et al., "Innovation of Women Garment Designs," 638f.
[78] Jones, "The Enigma of the Pleated Dress," 224.

garment. As compared to other textiles when draped, linen cloth creates lesser, yet deeper folds, which in turn become heavy and can restrict one's bodily movement.[79] Delving deeper into the experience of wearing Egyptian dress, I'm referring to Janet M. Johnstone, an archaeologist and clothing consultant for Ancient Egyptian clothing, who has intertwined historical observations with personal findings that stem from recreating ancient Egyptian garments. She explains how she reconstructed wrap-around dresses made from linen, even hand-pleating some of the pieces. These dresses were subsequently worn by several actresses on film sets, who were later asked about their embodied experiences.[80] For example, the so-called "complex-wrapped dresses", which are made of pleated fabric that is draped around the body, were deemed universally flattering, since they could adapt to every body, regardless of age, shape, or size.[81] The dresses were comfortable, yet made the women feel conscious of "the elegance and feel of the dresses at all times".[82] Johnston highlights the theatrical character of Ancient Egyptian dress, with wearers further supporting this statement by explaining that it made them feel powerful, beautiful, and elevated. The elegance exuded by these dresses, combined with the observation that energetic movement required small readjustments, may have culminated in the fact that most wearers "stood tall and walked gracefully".[83]

When reading these accounts, my mind instantaneously circles back to Issey Miyake and his incorporation of the pleat. The designer himself has even accredited Ancient Egypt as the birthplace of the pleat and stated that, by implementing pleating in a modern context, he is able to continue an "archaic tradition".[84] Although there are significant differences in material, technique, and style, I recognize parallels between the testimonies of wearing Ancient Egyptian dress and my own bodily experience of wearing Miyake. The sensation of comfort and a simultaneously heightened awareness of one's own body seems to transpire in both iterations of the pleat. This may be

[79] Jordan Galczynski and Robyn Price, "Fashioning Sensescapes through Ancient Egyptian Dance," in *Textiles in Motion: Dress for Dance in the Ancient World*, ed. Audrey Gouy (Oxford: Oxbow Books, 2024), 135.
[80] Johnstone, "Wrapping and Tying Ancient Egyptian New Kingdom Dresses," 62f.
[81] Ibid., 78.
[82] Ibid., 79.
[83] Ibid.
[84] Quinn, *Techno Fashion*, 152.

attributed to the fold's ability to expand and contract in unison with the wearer's body shape and movement, letting the garment seamlessly envelop the body and thus, creating a comfortable wearing experience. The more conscious bodily demeanor can be ascribed to various factors, such as the elegant character of the garment, its delicate fastening to the body through draping, as well as the qualities of the textile. For instance, since linen fabric does not easily retain pleated structures, the Egyptians potentially used starches to stiffen the fabric.[85] Equally to Miyake's pleats made of polyester, starched and pleated linen fabric could have encased the body in a rather stiff manner, yet would concurrently house malleable space between skin and garment, which culminates in a paradoxical blend of confinement and freedom.

It is to be noted that the pleat can affect the body in different ways, depending on how it is worn. On one hand, in loosely veiling the body, flowing and swinging widely, it reserves space for the wearer's movement. On the other hand, as a fitted garment, it stretches according to the body and follows its curves, its folds expanding only in response to the wearer's body. Hence, the aspect of draping impacts the fold's behavior towards the body as well. Tying this to the draped dresses in Ancient Egypt, they were adjusted to the individual and tightly wrapped around their body.[86] In line with this, Grömer and Rast-Eicher observe the following: "For Ancient Egypt it seems as if the accentuation of the natural body silhouette is an important design principle."[87]

Miyake's Madame-T stole offers grounds for an interesting comparison, as it can be worn in numerous ways, one of which is as wrapped around the body. In this figuration, it creates a similar effect to the Egyptian dress, being more tightly bound to the body, whilst retaining the fold's adaptability towards movement.

[85] Riggs, *Unwrapping Ancient Egypt*, 118f; Zaki et al., "Innovation of Women Garment Designs," 638f.
[86] Johnstone, "Wrapping and Tying Ancient Egyptian New Kingdom Dresses," 66.
[87] Grömer and Rast-Eicher, "To Pleat or Not to Pleat," 106.



Figure 2: Recreation of Ancient Egyptian wrap-around dress, made from pleated linen.



Figure 3: Pleats Please by Issey Miyake. Black Basic Madame-T Stole.

Ancient Greece

The technique of draping is not uniquely tied to Ancient Egypt, but can be detected to an even greater extent in Ancient Greek dress. The *chiton*, commonly worn by both men and women from the seventh to the first century B.C.E., was made of a rectangular piece of cloth, which was attached to the body with pins, belts, or brooches.[88] The fasteners "pushed" the fabric together so that it bunched, gathered, and compressed. Due to this, small, spontaneous folds would naturally form in the garment.[89] The *chiton* was either made of wool or linen, with the former being referred to as the *Doric* and the latter the *Ionic chiton.*[90] The linen fabric, as used for the *Ionic chiton,* enabled the formation of

[88] Laver, *Costume and Fashion*, 27.
[89] Mireille M. Lee, *Body, Dress, and Identity in Ancient Greece* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2015), 95.
[90] Laver, *Costume and Fashion*, 27.

more varied, flowy, and densely arranged folds, whereas, in comparison, woolen folds were broader, flatter, and straighter.[91]



Figure 4: The Charioteer of Delphi wearing the chiton, ca. 475 B.C.E.

Shifting the focus specifically to Greek sculpture, the fold is a particularly recurring and significant element. Influenced by Ancient Egyptian sculpture, the Greeks placed great emphasis on depicting the folds and drapes of clothing. Drapery was deliberately employed as an artistic device, expressing an ideal beauty as well as the dialectical relationship between body and cloth.[92] Within Classical drapery, the folds acted as structural support, holding and propping the body. Beyond this stabilizing function, it was also said to "reveal the body to advantage, emphasize its movements, and caress its contours".[93] Therefore, the solid folds in sculpture held a certain architectural agency, not only in regard to the construction, but also in how the depicted body was formed, shaped, and presented. Initially, Greek drapery in art was used to enhance the natural and nude body, as long as it was male. While cloth was meant to veil women's

[91] Ibid.; Lee, *Body, Dress, and Identity in Ancient Greece*, 109f.
[92] Chen and Cao, "Research on the Drapery in Ancient Greek Sculptures," 31f.
[93] Hollander, *Seeing Through Clothes*, 3.

"nakedness", for men, it aided in accentuating their bare bodies.[94] It was customary for women's bodies to stay hidden under the fabric, with their bare skin concealed, and their curves modeled by the shape of the folds.[95] For the male figure, drapes were employed to amplify and complement his natural beauty, functioning primarily as ornamentation.[96] In this context, the fold can be recognized as detached from the body, released from its primal function of enclothing it. Consequently, it possesses the power to exist in its own right. The sculptures of the Hellenistic period further illustrate the departure of the fold's dependence on the body. Here, the artists prioritized complex and detailed depictions of the textures of cloth, showing bodies wrapped in thin fabrics and embellished by a multitude of delicately layered lines. This shift in the body-fold relationship led to both male and female bodies being subordinated to the intricate and numerous folds imprinted on the material that wrapped around its surface.[97]

When unfolding the Greek drape in its lived and embodied dimension, the aspect of gender comes to the forefront once again. The fold in Greek dress represented femininity, both in regard to textile fabrication as well as moral symbolism. Women were "ideologically connected to the production of textiles", therefore wearing complex, draped garments could convey and underscore their feminine aptitude for textile manufacturing.[98] Additionally, the folds served as a way of "reifying ideological concepts of restriction and enclosure in female life".[99] In contrast to the function of the drape for male bodies, namely displaying status and character, for women, it embodied oppressive qualities exclusively assigned to the female sex, thus entailing a sartorial confinement to gender roles.[100]

Similarly to the pleat in Ancient Egypt, the Greeks understood the fold as the embodiment of status and wealth. Thus, the organization of the folds on the body and

---

[94] I have adopted Mireille M. Lee's figure of speech, referring to women's unclothed bodies as "naked" instead of "nude". This is based on the Ancient Greek conception of women's bodies as "antithetical" to male bodies. See Lee, *Body, Dress, and Identity in Ancient Greece*, 182.
[95] Hollander, *Seeing Through Clothes*, 11f.
[96] Ibid., 5f.
[97] Chen and Cao, "Research on the Drapery in Ancient Greek Sculptures," 35; Hollander, *Seeing Through Clothes*, 10.
[98] Lee, *Body, Dress, and Identity in Ancient Greece*, 91.
[99] Cleland, Davies, and Llewellyn-Jones, *Greek and Roman Dress from A to Z*, 73.
[100] Ibid.

their maintenance carried symbolic significance and enabled social distinction. On the one hand, complex drapes represented a higher status, since "creating and maintaining them required skill, control and relatively leisurely movement, as they involved large quantities of fabric".[101] The *chiton* and its mani(folds) deterred the body from seamlessly moving through space, due to the garment's copious amounts of volume, pleats that would twist and tangle once set in motion by rash movements, as well as restrictive sleeves.[102] Hence, it was not suitable work attire and epitomized the notion of leisure. In this context, since the elaborate folds required such disciplined demeanor and bodily composure, the interaction between body and fold can be interpreted as emblematic of one's position in the social hierarchy.[103] On the other hand, the complex drapes were associated with the idea of wealth, since vast quantities of fabric were necessary to create plentiful folds.[104]

When it comes to the specific pleating techniques of the Ancient Greeks, it is uncertain how specifically the folds were created or maintained in the cloth, since no complete items of clothing have survived. Moreover, it is unclear whether the depictions of pleated cloth in the arts accurately represent how the fold physically manifested itself in the Greek wardrobe, as they are likely comprised of stylized representations.[105] Some garments were presumably not permanently pleated, but relied solely on the folds that innately occur once fabric is wrapped around the body. However, various unspecified methods may have been implemented to increase their longevity and to permanently solidify them in fabric.[106] It is speculated that a seam could have aided in holding the pleats together, or that the folds were first hand-pleated and afterwards held in place by the means of either glue, or by soaking the fabric in a starch solution, tying it together, and letting it sun-dry.[107]

---

[101] Ibid.
[102] Lee, *Body, Dress, and Identity in Ancient Greece*, 110.
[103] Cleland, Davies, and Llewellyn-Jones, *Greek and Roman Dress from A to Z*, 51.
[104] Ibid., 73.
[105] Lee, *Body, Dress, and Identity in Ancient Greece*, 89.
[106] Spantidaki, "The Embellishment Techniques of Classical Greek Textiles," 41.
[107] See ibid.; Zaki et al., "Innovation of Women Garment Designs," 639; Hollander, *Seeing Through Clothes*, 5; Huang, "In-Between Pleats," 8.

Just as complex as its folds is the relationship between the pleat and the body in Ancient Greece. As the aforementioned paragraphs indicate, it was engaged in a continuous game of either veiling or accentuating the nude, sculpted body, depending on how it was gendered. The fold was ideologically laden, thus, once it was draped around the body, it bestowed its wearers with desirable characteristics or reinforced gender norms. When it comes to the sensual experience of the pleat, the sculptures of the Hellenistic period aimed at "making the flat fabric have a three-dimensional effect, […] making the drapery contrast with the healthy and elegant human body and complement each other".[108] Hence, the texture of the pleat, its entrapment of shadows within its deep folds, and the bright reflection of light on its surface carried great significance for creating a strong visual contrast. These folds ultimately served as a strong counterpart to the "smooth" human body they draped.[109] Moving from the marble fold towards the fold in dress, I refer to a study by Leyre Morgado-Roncal, Juliane Müller, and Marisa Lerbizi, where the *chiton* was reconstructed, based on cloth samples, previous research, and ancient sources such as iconography or literature. This experimental approach intended to provide new insights into Ancient Greek dress, including the quality and composition of the textiles, their functionality, sensory aspects, and more.[110] Apart from observations regarding the challenges in appropriately replicating the look of the folds, it includes findings on its interaction with the body, moving beyond a merely decorative function towards an affective quality. The authors acknowledge that the fold holds "expressive visual power" and impacts the wearer's perception. In addition, aspects such as the shape of the dress, how it molds and falls down on the body, are affected by the pleat. Another finding of particular interest to this thesis is the observation that "the pleated structure stimulates the senses, visual and aural, resulting in a wish to touch and feel the garment".[111] The folds in the fabric create an enticing texture, which in turn awakes a desire to interact with the dress. Taking a close look at the finely molded pleats in Greek sculpture, this evocative dimension

[108] Chen and Cao, "Research on the Drapery in Ancient Greek Sculptures," 35.
[109] Ibid., 35f.
[110] Leyre Morgado-Roncal, Juliane Müller, and Marisa Kerbizi, "Towards Textile Narratives: A Cross-Over Perspective on Textile Imagery in Statuary, Iconography, and Literature," in *Textile Crossroads: Exploring European Clothing, Identity, and Culture across Millennia* vol. 10 (2024), 222f.
[111] Morgado-Roncal, Müller, and Kerbizi, "Towards Textile Narratives," 229.

becomes heightened. The folds are not just an aesthetic or symbolic feature, but their depth, texture, and volume also generate a highly sensory experience.

Mariano Fortuny's Delphos Gown

Taking a far leap into the early 20th century, traces of Ancient Greek and Egyptian costumes persevere, particularly in the pleated silk creations by the artist Mariano Fortuny y Madrazo.[112] Nonetheless, across the timespan from Ancient Greece to the 20th century, the pleat carried on its legacy throughout the Roman and Medieval Ages; the Renaissance; and was a significant element of the Baroque in the 18th century.[113] However, shifting the focus back to Fortuny, his implementation of the Ancient pleat reintroduced body-responsive folds back into the otherwise restrictive sartorial norms for women at the time. His experimental attitude and interest in various arts and technologies culminated in successful inventions across multiple fields, such as electricity and lighting for stage design and photography, or new techniques for textile manipulation.[114] The *Delphos* gown was one of his innovative creations, grounded in "historic styles both in structural form and surface patterning".[115] The dress, which was first created in 1907, consisted of finely pleated silk, and was notably inspired by the Ancient Greek sculpture *The Charioteer of Delphi* (see Figure 4).[116] Evidently, within its delicate pleats made of silk, the gown enfolds the styles of historical eras, with Classical Greece located at its depths. The long *Delphos* dress covered the body in a rather loose manner, yet simultaneously flowed softly over the body's contours and curves. Attached on the sides were Venetian glass pearls, which weighed down the fabric and served as an aesthetic detail. Whilst the dress intended to accentuate the beauty of the female body, it also freed it from sartorial conventions and thus, "revolutionized" women's fashion at the time.[117] In contrast to the corseted and tight-fitted styles of the

[112] Breward, *Fashion*, 97. Drapery and pleating resembling Ancient Greek or Egyptian dress can also be detected in the works of designers such as Madame Grés, Madeleine Vionnet, or Paul Poiret.
[113] Grömer and Rast-Eicher, "To Pleat or Not to Pleat"; Zaki et al. "Innovation of Women Garment Designs" 639f; Hollander, *Seeing Through Clothes*, 58f.
[114] Wendy Ligon Smith, *Fortuny: Time, Space, Light* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2022), 11-17.
[115] Ibid., 70.
[116] Polan and Tredre, *The Great Fashion Designers*, 25; Smith, *Fortuny*, 75.
[117] Akiko Fukai, ed., *Fashion: Eine Modegeschichte Vom 18. Bis 20. Jahrhundert* (Köln: Taschen GmbH, 2015), 332 and 335.

nineteenth century, the *Delphos* gown acted as a trailblazer for new dress codes of the twentieth century, as it "represented a liberation" for women's fashion.[118] The gown was initially intended for private wear at home, although due to its permissive nature for movement, women soon began wearing the dresses in public settings, such as for performances by actresses and dancers. Particularly in regard to previous dance costumes, the light, unrestrictive, and even liquid feel of the garment, combined with its ability to illuminate the body in motion, proved advantageous. Factoring into this may also have been the adaptability of the dress, as it was not produced according to specific sizes, but instead equipped with "points of adjustment" on the inside that could be modified according to one's unique body shape.[119] Moreover, the uniquely rippled effect of the gown's pleats highlighted its fluid nature. This contributed to its allure, since the fine horizontal lines running through the vertical folds generate an "additional interplay with light and give the fabric a deeper sense of movement".[120]

In 1909, Fortuny patented the pleating technique he developed for the *Delphos* gown. The process is very loosely outlined in the documents of the patent, and the exact materials and methods employed for the creation of the dress remain a mystery. Nonetheless, the patent mentions an innovative machine, which was presumably equipped with heated cylindrical rollers.[121] The creation of the silk folds is believed to have been accomplished through thermal pleating. Presumably, heat was applied once the material was in wet condition, resulting in the silk retaining folds based on "material memory".[122] However, based on the irregular look of the pleats, Kathleen Kearney, who used to be a fashion researcher and teacher at the University of Idaho, proposes that Fortuny utilized a Japanese technique for pleating, the so-called *shibori* technique which involves pole-wrapping. To briefly summarize this method, a piece of fabric is wrapped diagonally around a pole, secured in place by a thread, and compressed along the pole.[123] Once the pole was removed, Fortuny's patented machine could have subsequentially been of help to straighten the fabric again. This proposed method has been tested by

[118] Ibid., 332; Polan and Tredre, *The Great Fashion Designers*, 25.
[119] Smith, *Fortuny*, 75f and 78.
[120] Kanda, "Under Tension, Under Pressure, Making Waves," 83.
[121] Farinelli et al., "Unveiling Polychrome Printing Methods on Textiles," 1299.
[122] Smith, *Fortuny*, 76; Polan and Tredre, *The Great Fashion Designers*, 26.
[123] Kearney, "Mariano Fortuny's Delphos Robe," 87ff.

Tsai-Chun Huang, who attests that the results highly resemble the original, since, just like Fortuny's pleats, they look more creased and display a variation in width.[124] Offering a counter-perspective, L. Leann Kanda, an Associate Professor of Behavioral Ecology at Ithaca College, declares in her experimental research on Fortuny's pleats that the proposed *shibori* technique is insufficient for the realistic reconstruction of the original garment. Instead, she believes high-pressure steam setting and the usage of stitching are able to provide greater accuracy.[125] Moreover, she refers to Fortuny's patented machine as an "undulation" machine, indicating that it was intended to create soft waves in the pleated fabric rather than straightening it.[126] She also mentions a theory suggesting the use of a specific glue consisting of egg whites, which would facilitate the pleating process, as it would stiffen the fabric and hence, make it easier to control.[127] Evidently, the mystery behind the construction of Fortuny's *Delphos* gown persists, as scholars in the field have not been able to determine the exact pleating methods thus far. One aspect that is certain however, was the longevity of the pleat. Time was able to leave its mark on the garments, gradually unfolding the pleat. For instance, wet cleaning and even "normal" wear would diminish the sharpness of the fold. This can be attributed to the molecular structure of silk, which inhibits it from adopting a permanently folded texture.[128] Most typically, the folds in the mid-seat area on the backside of the dress would lose their shape.[129] Nonetheless, the quality of the pleat was substantial enough for certain women to wear their *Delphos* throughout their lifetime.[130]

[124] Huang, "In-Between Pleats," 50f.
[125] Kanda, "Under Tension, Under Pressure, Making Waves," 100.
[126] Ibid., 93.
[127] Ibid., 85.
[128] Kearney, "Mariano Fortuny's Delphos Robe," 90.
[129] Sparks, "Explorations In Pleated Fabric Garment Structures," 41.
[130] Smith, *Fortuny*, 76.



Figure 5: The Delphos gown from behind.

Regardless of the mystery behind Fortuny's silk pleats, the only tangible remains are the preserved garments that are embellished by these exquisite folds. The texture within the fabric invites a play with texture, light and shadow, as well as movement. What ensues is a highly sensory experience of the gown, most predominantly for the wearer, but also for the observer.

Fortunately, I was able to get in contact with Tonie Lewenhaupt, who is a costume historian, fashion writer, author, as well as a fashion collector. She owned a *Delphos* gown (dated back to ca. 1908) and later gifted it to the Röhsska Museum in Gothenburg.[131] Her donation to the museum even included some of Issey Miyake's pleated pieces. Thus, Tonie's experience of having worn and felt both Fortuny's and Miyake's folded creations on her body allows for a direct comparison of these different iterations of the pleat. When asked about her first interaction with the *Delphos* gown, Tonie relishes the memory of one of her birthdays. That day, she received the gown as a gift from her husband, wrapped up in a tiny package.

[131] The museum currently exhibits the dress next to two of Miyake's designs as well as other pleated items such as a few lamps, a jumpsuit for children by *Petit Pli*, and a woolen handbag by *van Deurs*.



Figure 6: In order to retain the pleats, the Delphos dress was tightly twisted and stored in a small box.

The *Delphos* made its appearance the same day, as she decided to wear it for the evening. However, the occasions for wear were limited to that night, as well as one other time Tonie put it on to take photos, due to her being afraid of destroying it. However, Tonie notes how the fragile silk gown beautifully enveloped the body, flowing over its curves and aligning with its movements: “the Fortuny dress, it falls over you, very softly, very nicely, very calmly, and it stays on the body. It moves with the movement of a person, but it obeys the movement of a person. So, it's like the dress really belongs to the body. It has no other will than belonging to the body”. In contrast, this synergy between body and dress was not detectable in Miyake’s garments, as for her, the pleats led a life of their own. In order to prevent the fabric from moving independently from the body, she recalls having to be very still and calm. As soon as the fabric was set in motion, it would move away from her, resulting in an unappealing effect. The garment did not “cooperate” with her, so that whilst wearing it, she was continuously questioning whether it looked good on her body. To her, the Miyake garments only looked alluring when subjected to an absolute absence of motion, as for instance, hanging on a dress doll. During our conversation, she does acknowledge how the Fortuny gown has made an impact on her embodied experiences, stating that: “maybe if I hadn't had the experience of having had that Fortuny dress, and had felt that softness and that belonging, quite another character sort of, maybe I would have accepted this Miyake *Pleats Please* much, much more”.



Figure 7: Exhibition Section at Röhsska titled 'Innovation - Permissive Shape Using Folded Fabric'. From left to right: Petit Pli childrenswear, two Issey Miyake garments and Fortuny's Delphos gown



Figure 8: A closer look at the pleated texture of the Delpos gown.

When it comes to designers of the 20th and 21st Centuries who implemented the pleat into their designs, this chapter has decidedly reduced itself to Mariano Fortuny. This does not suggest that contributions by designers such as Madame Grés, Mary McFadden, or Roberto Capucci are insignificant to the history of pleats. Rather, Fortuny's *Delphos* dress was explored in depth because of its iconic status; its aesthetic rooted in Ancient Greek dress; and the opportunity it presented to receive more profound insights into its embodied dimension through Tonie's narrative. Lastly, looking at contemporary fashion, the pleat persists. For example, the renowned clothing lines *Pleats Please* and *Homme Plissé* continue to be a significant part of the Miyake house today. In addition, folded shapes are a recurring element in styles by up-and-coming designers, as well as already-established names in the industry.[132] The multifaceted history of the pleat and its lingering presence in contemporary fashion offer rich grounds for further scholarly attention. Departing from the historical analysis of the pleat, the following chapter will investigate it from a theoretical perspective, uncovering the deeper meaning that lies within the fold in fashion.

[132] See e.g. contemporary designers such as Robert Wun, Iris van Herpen, Peter Do, Jennifer Blom, or Gnyuki Torimaru incorporate folded structures and pleated textures in their fashion designs.

Chapter Two: Thinking in Folds

This theoretical chapter takes a closer look at the interplay between cloth and flesh. Once entrapped in the pleats of fabric, the space between these two entities becomes a kind of membrane, one that allows the fabric to either move closer to the skin or fold itself away from its wearer. While Russel W. Belk understands possessions, and in extension clothes, as symbolic extensions of ourselves, ones that act as building blocks of our identity, one may go a step further.[133] Hence, in regard to the fabrics that wrap around our bodies, we may even be able to perceive them as also physically intertwined with our core being. This proposition is more clearly laid out by philosophers Merleau-Ponty and Deleuze. Although their theories present very different perspectives and ideas, what ultimately ties them together is the belief that the external, physical world inevitably impacts and transforms the self, who we fundamentally are. Embedding the pleat into this line of thought, it becomes particularly crucial to ask how exactly folded fabrics interact, affect, and transform the bodies they drape. By interrogating the pleat and its implications for lived experience and, for that matter, human existence, I want to explore the underlying power that lies within the materiality of pleated clothing, something that has previously been widely disregarded within academia. More specifically, the focus on Issey Miyake, whose pleated designs were predominantly meant for daily wear, illustrates the urgency of such an endeavor, as the pleat in an everyday context more closely and frequently interacts with the body. Thus, there is a higher sense of urgency, since Miyake's pleated clothing items are perpetually engaged in a reciprocal relationship with their respective wearers.

In tandem with Miyake's Japanese origins, conceptions of the dressed body may vary depending on culture and heritage. By incorporating Japanese notions of the body in correlation to clothing, the fold as a theoretical subject can be examined in a more meticulous manner. For example, the concept of *ma*, which refers to the interval between certain entities, enables a more tangible understanding of the malleable space between

[133] Russell W. Belk, "Possessions and the Extended Self," in *Journal of Consumer Research* vol. 15, no. 2 (September 1, 1988): 139–68.

pleat and skin.[134] It can be applied to different contexts, although in regard to clothing, it originally referenced a body dressed in the Japanese kimono.[135] In the case of Miyake's pleats, I deem it nonetheless fitting, since Miyake himself has referenced the kimono as a guiding principle for his designs: "I learned about the space between the body and the fabric from the traditional kimono . . . not the style, but the space."[136] This incorporation of Japanese modes of thought allows for a multifaceted investigation of Miyake's fashion, and more broadly, the fold.

The Fold as a Phenomenological Phenomenon

Departing from the fundamental idea that the body is the primal site of human perception, Merleau-Ponty stresses how human existence is inherently tied to the embodied experience of the world. Here, the body is not just a "vehicle" for receiving and encountering the world, but it also constitutes our being. Moreover, the perceiving body is affected by the interactions with the outside world, which, in extension, also shapes one's inner self.[137] Narrowing the view specifically to fashion, clothes do not only offer a visual experience, but on a more substantial level, the garments that clothe us affect our "body schema", a term that refers to "an experience of my body in the world".[138] Merleau-Ponty also points to the significance of tactile experiences for embodied subjectivity. He discerns between active and passive touch, with the former encompassing the sensation of touch by body parts that are "ordinarily covered" or bodily surfaces that lay on the inside.[139] This passive sensation mirrors the "state of one's own body", instead of offering a tactile experience where the object is an active agent.[140] Expanding on passive touch and the role of clothing, garments become a mediating force between the bare body and the external world. In consequence, they intimately affect the body, governing how it haptically receives its surroundings. Moreover, as they turn into

---

[134] Richard B. Pilgrim, "Intervals ('Ma') in Space and Time: Foundations for a Religio-Aesthetic Paradigm in Japan," in *History of Religions* vol. 25, no. 3 (February 1986): 255.
[135] Kazuko Koike, "3 – Developing Contemporaneity," in *Issey Miyake*, ed. Midori Kitamura (Cologne: Taschen, 2024), 48.
[136] Issey Miyake, cited in English, *Japanese Fashion Designers*, 20.
[137] Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*.
[138] Ibid., 142.
[139] Ibid., 328.
[140] Ibid.

a sort of second skin, their own tactile qualities become a fundamental aspect of the body schema.

In *The Visible and the Invisible,* Merleau-Ponty frequently refers to the term *flesh*, which he intentionally uses to illustrate the interweaving between body and world. For him, "flesh is not matter, is not mind, is not substance", but an "element" of our existence in the world, the tangible substance of one's core being.[141] The word is not just designated to the human body, but includes the *flesh* of the world. Merleau-Ponty alludes to the notion that the body and the world are made from the same *flesh*, they overlap and exert power over each other.[142] In this context, he notes: "our flesh lines and even envelops all the visible and tangible things with which nevertheless it is surrounded, the world and I are within one another".[143] In reference to Deleuze, who will be more thoroughly discussed later, one may frame the intertwining of body and world as a process of "folding" into each other. In the case of Issey Miyake, body and cloth merge and correspond with each other, with the garment and the body sharing the same *flesh*. The designer has also acknowledged this amalgamation between body and (folded) fabric, by stating that "my clothes become part of someone, part of them physically".[144] The fold engages in a dialogue with the body – it not only bears itself upon the body but also carries the capacity to transform in response to its shape and comportment through space.

Naturally then, the dynamic body and the pleat are in constant conjunction, perpetually generating impulses in one another that subsequently manifest in their *flesh*. The wearer does not just fill the empty space in between the folds of the fabric, but in accordance with its movement, the garment increases in volume and alters its shape continuously. Even if there is no intentional movement involved, the living body is never completely static. Its skin is a pulsating surface that moves with every breath, permanently generating micro-movements. Thus, the space between skin and textile is in constant flux, it trembles accordingly and instigates a transfer of movement from the

---

[141] Merleau-Ponty, *The Visible and the Invisible: Followed by Working Notes* (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1968), 139.
[142] Ibid., 248.
[143] Ibid., 123.
[144] Metropolis Editors, "The A to Z of Issey Miyake," Metropolis, May 10, 2016, https://metropolismag.com/viewpoints/the-a-to-z-of-issey-miyake/.

body towards the cloth. In the case of Miyake's pleat, the body sets the garment in motion and induces responsive behavior. The stiffness and simultaneous elasticity of Miyake's heat-pressed polyester folds allow it to invariably house a certain space between skin and fabric, as well as stretch correspondingly to the lived body it clothes, yielding enough malleable room for unrestricted movement. In comparison with the *Delphos* gown, a similar adaptability of the garment can be identified, although the space between skin and silk pleat is minimized (see figure 7). Here, the pockets of pliability lie within the delicate silk folds, which flatten or bend with the wearer's curves. Similarly, Miyake's infamous *Plastic Body* (fall/winter 1980-81), reduces the space between the body and the garment significantly. However, due to its firm structure, it infringes upon the body's ability to move, twist, or warp. As a "second skin of glossy metal", it is a hard, sculptural shell that tightly traces the body's silhouette, culminating in a vaguely folded structure at the midriff.[145] The garment becomes the body, very literally sharing the same *flesh*.[146]



Figure 9: Issey Miyake's Plastic Bodice from fall/winter 1980-81.

[145] "Bustier 1980-1981 {autumn-Winter 1980–81} ISSEY MIYAKE, Tokyo (Fashion House) Issey MIYAKE (Designer)," NGV, accessed April 10, 2025, https://www.ngv.vic.gov.au/explore/collection/work/57618/.

[146] It is to be noted that Miyake's pleated garment from his *Pleats Please* or *Homme Plissé* line are intended to be worn for daily wear, whereas the plastic bodice is not a universal, everyday piece of clothing.

At a later stage in this chapter, I delve deeper into the relationship between body and cloth, investigating the theme outside of a Western frame of mind with a focus on materiality, and more specifically, the space in between.

Lastly, in problematizing Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology, I want to point out his negligence of gendered lived experience. In line with some feminist scholars, who have both criticized his gender indifference and/or expanded his phenomenological concept to include the lived reality of particularly female, queer, and non-white bodies, I also deem it crucial to include a variety of subjectivities in the phenomenological discussion.[147] Especially in regard to Merleau-Ponty's mention of the "permanence" of the body, one can understand the body as the primal point of contact with the world.[148] Its absence is unthinkable, as it would imply the disappearance of existence. Thus, "The body imposes a perspective on us that we cannot simply do away with".[149] In turn, we must conclude that the gendered body, for instance, very distinctly impacts embodied experience. As a part of their corporeality, women's bodies encounter the world differently from men's, both due to their physical attributes and the socio-cultural context that their gendered selves are embedded in.[150] It becomes evident that various specificities of embodied difference, such as gender, sexuality, race, age, or disability, are necessarily enmeshed in the *flesh* of the body. Going back to the reciprocity between the body and the world, the body is always subjected to the social reality of its external environment, and in this context more specifically, to patriarchy. Gender norms permeate the subjective body, its experiences, behavior, movement, and perception. The

[147] For example, Dorothea Olkowski and Gail Weiss thoroughly discuss Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology through a feminist lens, see Olkowski and Weiss, *Feminist Interpretations of Maurice Merleau-Ponty* (University Park, Pa.: Pennsylvania State University Press, 2006). Elizabeth Grosz delves deeper into how Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology previously has, and can be reconfigured for feminist scholarship, see Grosz, "Merleau-Ponty and Irigaray in the Flesh."
[148] See Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, 92-95.
[149] Silvia Stoller, "Asymmetrical Genders: Phenomenological Reflections on Sexual Difference," in *Hypatia* vol. 20, no. 2 (2005): 19.
[150] On the physical implications of sex, see Young, *On Female Body Experience: Throwing Like a Girl and Other Essays*. On the social implications of sex, see Sandra Lee Bartky, "Narcissism, Femininity and Alienation," in *Fashion Theory*, ed. Malcom Barnard (London: Routledge, 2020), 677–91.

body internalizes and incorporates these structures in its body schema and simultaneously reproduces and "normalizes" them.[151]

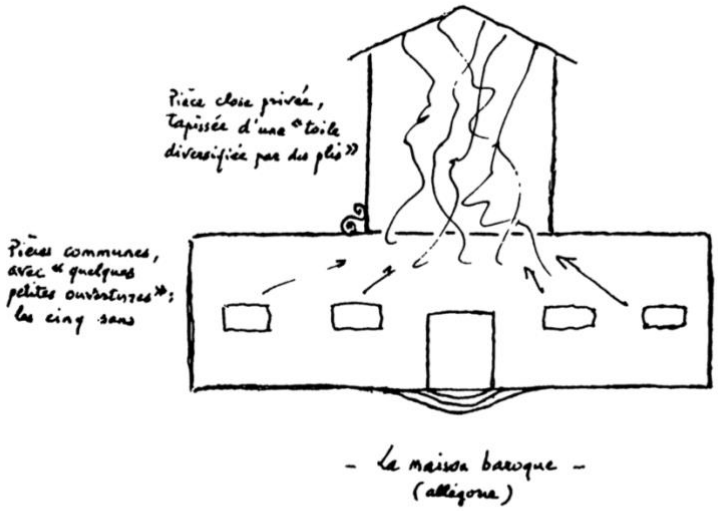
In front of this frame of thought, the dressed self can both embody and express traditional gender roles. The hegemonic structures of the external world invariably impose themselves on the lived body, since the way a person presents themselves, moves through space, perceives and engages with the world, is deeply embedded in their given sociocultural setting. As Iris Young further explains: "Contexts of discourse and interaction position persons in systems of evaluation and expectations which often implicate their embodied being".[152] A deviation from normative modes of gendered dress can be filled with the risk of social scrutiny, judgment, or bewilderment. Circling back to Issey Miyake, his conscious attention to the space between body and cloth, combined with the flat construction of his garments, oftentimes culminated in oversized and formless creations, which in turn "concealed the curves of the female form and resulted in gender-neutral or unisex clothing".[153] Thus, for the investigation of the lived experience of the pleat, it is indispensable to consider the social dimension of gender as well as the materiality of the body it drapes. Additionally, the interplay between Miyake's "genderless" styles and the sexed body opens up room for further discussion, which will resurface in the last chapter. Merleau-Ponty's theory of phenomenology builds a preliminary foundation for understanding the body as the primal source of consciousness, which can additionally be expanded upon in regard to how axes of identity fold into the bodily experience of the world. Going a step further, Deleuze's conception of the *fold* digs deeper into how the outer world folds into the human body. More precisely, it sheds light on how the fold, both in a literal and metaphysical sense, may even transform the body, and in extension, the self, rendering it a body that is fluid, dynamic, and in *becoming.*

---

[151] Julia Jansen and Maren Wehrle, "The Normal Body: Female Bodies in Changing Contexts of Normalization and Optimization," in *New Feminist Perspectives on Embodiment*, eds. Clara Fischer and Luna Dolezal (Cham: Springer International Publishing, 2018), 38.
[152] Young, *On Female Body Experience: Throwing Like a Girl and Other Essays*, 17.
[153] Sandhya Lalloo-Morar, "Design Innovation by Japanese Designers Miyake, Kawakubo, and Yamamoto," in *Berg Encyclopedia of World Dress and Fashion: East Asia*, ed. John E. Vollmer, vol. 6 (Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2010).

The Enfolding of Self and Garment

In his book *The Fold: Leibniz and the Baroque*, first released in 1988, Deleuze investigates the fold in the context of the Baroque. He bases his exploration of the fold on Leibniz's philosophies, yet, in a divergence to Leibniz, he renders it dynamic, fluid, and perpetually in conjunction with the external world. In connection to this, he paints a picture of the *Baroque House*, an allegory of exactly this two-folded dynamic. The two interconnected floors, with the lower one acting as an opening into the external world and the upper one as the chamber of the soul, vividly illustrate the fluid nature of human consciousness and existence, emphasizing the inevitable enfolding of our surroundings into our souls.[154]



The Baroque House—(allegory)

[diagram: a closed, private room, draped with a 'cloth diversified by folds' / common rooms with 'a few small openings': the five senses]

Figure 10: The Baroque House (allegory).

Beyond his illustration of the *Baroque House*, he reconfigures Leibniz's conception of the *monad*, a term that describes an interior with dual flooring. In essence, the *monad* encompasses the soul, yet, for Leibniz, it exists for and within itself without any windows to the outside.[155] As an enclosed cell, it is completely separated from the outside and functions autonomously within its own borders. The upper floor of the

[154] Deleuze, *The Fold*, 4f.
[155] Ibid., 25.

monad is light, whereas the lower one is dark. This duality of light and darkness represents knowledge and uncertainty, the core principle of being.[156] Deleuze reimagines Leibniz's *monad* by breaking down its façades, allowing both floors to fold into each other, as well as the world folding into it from the outside. Consequently, each *monad* "includes every series of the states of the world", and thus, encapsulates and expresses the entire world from a different point of view.[157] As such, it can be perceived as the source of subjectivity; a building block for the self; or even a sort of ego.[158] In this regard, the significance of the fold is once again highlighted, since it "allows the world to be placed within the subject (as monad) so that the subject can be in and of the world at large".[159] However, this folding between world and *monad* is not one-sided, as both the outside folds inward and the inside folds outward. As much as it is a "sensuous entity that perceives and expresses the development of the world", it can also create new folds of virtual potentials that in turn fold into the real world and thus, become actualized.[160] In this regard, Deleuze points to the *pleats of matter* and prompts the question of whether the actualization of the virtual also requires a material realization. In response, he notes that material folds may have the capacity to "reduplicate the folds in the soul", and although he doesn't answer his original question with a definite "yes", he certainly leans towards it.[161]

This brings us back to the fold as a material phenomenon in fashion. In Deleuzian terms, the space between body and fabric allows for a "go-between – or go-betweens", a continuous process of folding and unfolding.[162] In this regard, Deleuze refers to the elements, which emancipate the physical folds in clothing from the body, and further "mediate, distend, and broaden the relation of clothing to the body".[163] Wind, water,

---

[156] Geoffrey C. Bowker, "A Plea for Pleats," in *Deleuzian Intersections: Science, Technology, Anthropology*, eds. Casper Bruun Jensen and Kjetil Rödje (New York: Berghahn Books, 2009), 125.
[157] Deleuze, *The Fold*, 28.
[158] Simon O'Sullivan, *Art Encounters Deleuze and Guattari* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2006), 123.
[159] Tom Conley, "Fifteen: Folds and Folding," in *Gilles Deleuze: Key Concepts*, ed. Charles J. Stivale (Oxon: Routledge, 2014), 199.
[160] Elisabet Yanagisawa, "The Fold: A Physical Model of Abstract Reversibility and Envelopment," in *Dark Precursor: Deleuze and Artistic Research*, eds. Paulo De Assis and Paolo Giudici (Leuven: Leuven University Press, 2017), 148.
[161] Deleuze, *The Fold*, 29.
[162] Ibid., 140.
[163] Ibid.

earth, and fire act as "derivative forces" that render the fold infinite and imbue it with spiritual meaning. Through this lens, the fold is both a dynamic and autonomous entity that, through its infinite foldings, generates a "form of expression".[164] Hence, it can act as an articulation of possibilities, meanings, or emotions, whilst simultaneously being able to fold them into existence. As *pleats of matter* and *folds of the soul*, the fold endlessly moves between material reality and thought, constituting a bridge between inside and outside.[165] More concretely, this passage between the material and the immaterial realm is permeable and invites an "infinite 'receptivity'".[166] In this sense, Giuliana Bruno poignantly remarks that "the fold is actually an elaborate mutual figuration of mind and matter. It is the form of their transformation".[167] Thus, the fold, as manifested in the fabric of a garment, enfolds the physical and mental sphere of subjectivity. It mediates the encounter and exchange between the individual and the world.

Through Deleuze's eyes, the fold can be read in two ways: one is the enfolding of *pleats of matter* into the *folds of the soul*, as illustrated in the *Baroque House,* and the other, the fold as force that can reduplicate the *folds of the soul*. In the former, the pleated garment enters the *Baroque House's* lower floor of matter through tiny windows, also referred to as "several small openings" (see figure 12).[168] With the five senses being located on this level, they allow for sensual experiences with material entities, which concurrently fold into the *folds of the soul* on the floor above.[169] As one wears the pleat, the fabric envelops the body, brushes one's skin, or fluidly wraps around the curves of the body, instigating a bodily encounter that inevitably addresses the senses. Metaphorically speaking, through the sensory encounters it produces, the garment is able to enter the *Baroque House* of self. In this process, fashion exceeds its representational function and becomes a highly intimate and formative element, infinitely folding into the self, entangling with one's soul, and even more so, folding into the *monads* of subjectivity. Consequently, the Deleuzian reading of Issey Miyake's pleats grants them

---

[164] Ibid., 39.
[165] Ibid.
[166] Ibid.
[167] Bruno, "Pleats of Matter, Folds of the Soul," 217.
[168] Deleuze, *The Fold*, 5.
[169] Ibid., 4f.

spiritual power and a certain sovereignty. Consequently, his folds have the potential to fold into their wearers, transgressing the physical border of skin and reaching into the chamber of the soul. Moreover, they are not submissive to the body they wrap around, but instead, constitute an autonomous force. As Anneke Smelik points out in this regard, the body is in consequence also freed from the materiality of the cloth.[170] Although Miyake's pleat exhibits a certain autonomy due to its stiff and sculptural qualities that naturally "impose" a specific form on the wearer's body, it is also highly malleable and adapts to the body's shape and movement. The stretchy and lightweight fabric enables the pleats to engage in a continuous process of expanding and shrinking. In the Deleuzian sense, it carries out an endless folding that surpasses the material realm and initiates a process of *becoming*. The third chapter, which investigates the lived reality of wearing the fold, will add to this discussion by providing personal insights into the interplay between *pleats of matter* and *folds of the soul*, how body and pleat communicate with each other, and thus, how a *becoming* may transpire in real life.

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari explore the concept of *becoming* in their book *A Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia*. The term, conceptualized as an inversion of the static notion of "being", is explored along different pillars, one of which is *becoming-woman.* This example offers a more vivid explanation of the term, as Deleuze and Guattari remark how women naturally enter a process of *becoming* due to their natural deviation from the default (men). Going beyond the female body, both a predisposed "abnormality" or a deliberately incorporated minority can initiate a *becoming*: "We can be thrown into a becoming by anything at all, by the most unexpected, most insignificant of things. You don't deviate from the majority unless there is a little detail that starts to swell and carries you off."[171] However, *becoming* is a practice that involves the active process of repetition inhabited by difference.[172] Therefore, small changes in repetition carry the potential to reconfigure human identity and transform it into a fluid, dynamic, and pliable entity.[173] In this frame of mind,

---

[170] Smelik, "Fashioning the Fold," 44.
[171] Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1987), 292.
[172] Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1994), 76.
[173] Smelik, "Gilles Deleuze: Bodies-without-Organs in the Folds of Fashion," in *Thinking Through Fashion: A Guide to Key Theorists*, eds. Rocamora and Smelik (London: I.B. Tauris, 2019), 167.

Deleuze's fold is precisely the force that connects the outer world to the subject, opening the body up to external entities that, in turn, induce an *assemblage*. Hence, once a "set of forces coalesces together", an *assemblage* occurs, which has the power to reconfigure traditional mechanisms, structures, or functions.[174] A body veiled, wrapped, or adorned with objects of fashion then finds itself in a transformative relationship to its counterpart, as both elements fold into each other and consequently generate a mutual *becoming.* Stephen Seely's exploration of the fashioned, *becoming* body sets no demarcation between Haute Couture and daily wear, concluding that "all clothing, even in its most quotidian, transforms the wearer, producing assemblages with the body".[175] Nonetheless, he posits the so-called "affective fashion" on a higher pedestal, as he believes it harnesses enough power to maximize the affective capacity of fashion.[176] By transforming the body in a more substantial manner, it pushes it beyond its natural limits, destabilizing dominant modes of stratification – how bodies are normatively organized, disciplined, or coded.[177] Circling back to Issey Miyake, I would argue that his pleats are situated at the intersection between everyday wear and highly transformative fashion. On one hand, the pleat's versatility and practicality give it a universal quality, making it a very "easy" piece to wear and style in a multitude of settings. On the other hand, as I have already touched upon and will further elaborate on in the following, it represents a deeper ideology, one that rejects and reconfigures sartorial conventions. Miyake's fluid folds engage in a dynamic *assemblage* with the body, opening it up to an endless folding-in and folding-out. Along with the pleats co-constructing the body's shape and silhouette, they eternally produce a difference in repetition (new foldings occur with every gesture or movement). Therefore, the body dressed in Miyake's pleats is engaged in a perpetual *becoming*, a transformation of the self that is as discreet as it is remarkable.

To finalize my discussion on Deleuze and Miyake, I deem it necessary to mention the second angle one may regard the fold. By enfolding both an inner and an outer side, folding always transpires in a double manner. In relation to the body it envelops, the fold

---

[174] Graham Livesey, "Assemblage," in *The Deleuze Dictionary Revised Edition*, ed. Adrian Parr (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2010), 18.
[175] Seely, "How Do You Dress a Body Without Organs?," 251.
[176] Ibid.
[177] In this context, Seely points to Alexander McQueen, Rei Kawakubo, Hussein Chalayan, and Gareth Pugh's contributions to fashion. Ibid., 248.

operates similarly, allowing for a reversal of the pleat folding into the wearer and instead, giving it the power to fold one's inner world outward as well. Giuliana Bruno touches upon this dual modus operandi and refers to the "affective fabric" of the fold, as found in fashion, film, and architecture.[178] Particularly the fold in fashion – manifested in an endlessly flowing pleat that opens and closes in response to the body's movement – she identifies it as "the very architecture of the soul".[179] Taking Deleuze's theory of the fold and Bruno's expansive application of it into consideration, the fold can be regarded as both a constituent of emotions and feelings, as well as their mirror. In this regard, we revisit Miyake's Madame-T stole, which Bruno uses to further illustrate her point. The stole's very simple construction invites the wearer to wrap it around their body in a very individual and creative fashion. The endless styling possibilities force the wearer to determine how the garment will be formed, warped, and tied on their body. As an architectural piece, it becomes a home that one must build anew every time they wish to house. The inhabitant's decision-making process may happen unconsciously, yet regardless, it is substantially informed by their inner world. In this regard, Bruno concludes the following: "Every time you unfold it, this architecture tells you who you are and how you feel, even if you do not know it."[180]

Lastly, one may even connect Miyake's pleats with the *monad*, rendering them a representation of a larger design philosophy. The *monad*, in this case understood as Issey Miyake's subjective worldview, encompasses his stance on fashion and, in a broader sense, on the world itself. Furthermore, the *monad* enfolds his personal history, heritage, and experiences, which all come together to form his unique point of view. In turn, it becomes actualized in his physical designs. In this sense, Miyake's work can be considered *monadic.* For instance, Miyake's interest in the relationship between body and garment can be traced back all the way to his first designs, which were tight-fitting styles that treated fabric as a second skin.[181] Shifting the perspective to his *Pleats Please* line, it follows the same principle, although enacted in a very different manner, as these garments encase the body subtly, allowing it to be liberated, whilst simultaneously co-

[178] Bruno, "Pleats of Matter, Folds of the Soul," 221.
[179] Ibid.
[180] Ibid., 223.
[181] Kitamura, *Issey Miyake*, 48.

constructing its silhouette. Not only his choice of collaboration partners or the models presenting his clothes, but also his pleated creations themselves, further embody his empathetic and democratic stance towards the human body.[182] Particularly in regard to female bodies, his solidarity towards women materializes in the pleat, which prioritizes functionality and comfort over restrictive beauty. The garment's folds release women from a hypersexualized stylization of their bodies and enable them to move freely through everyday life.



Figure 11: Issey Miyake in collaboration with photographer Yuriko Takagi.

Miyake's designs are emblematic of his experimental, unconventional, and technological approach towards fashion. His innovative technique for creating folds turned the standard approach for pleating on its head, as the fabric was cut and sewn prior to heat-pressing, instead of the other way around.[183] His boundless conception of fashion is exemplified in his implementation of unusual materials, such as plastics, rattan and bamboo, metal wire, or paper.[184] Since in his words, "Anything can be clothing."[185]

---

[182] These few examples further illustrate Miyake's inclusive and egalitarian vision: he initiated a collaboration with women's-rights activist Fusae Ichikawa in 1974; presented his fashion show "Issey Miyake and Twelve Black Girls" in 1976, which exclusively put black models in the spotlight (particularly in the context of their vast underrepresentation in the fashion scene); hired a variety of people of different ages and occupations to model for his PERMANENTE line between 1986 and 1990; collaborated with female photographer Yuriko Takagi from 1995 to 1999, who visited local communities in Kenya, China, India and Morocco to capture Issey's garments on local bodies.
[183] Kitamura, *Issey Miyake*, 153.
[184] E.g. the *Plastic Body,* the *Rattan Body,* the *Wire Body,* or the *Abura-gami Coat.*
[185] Issey Miyake cited in Kitamura, *Issey Miyake*, 90.

My interview with Ulrika, a former material developer for the Issey Miyake house, further validates this core principle of the brand. As a "material-driven and technology-driven fashion house", the pleats enfold one of the designer's core principles, namely the focus on innovating and developing garment production through cutting-edge technology. This can be traced back to the origin of Miyake's pleat: Ulrika tells me that, contrary to constructing folds in order to sculpt and create elaborate silhouettes, his objective was to "try to blast an idea from within rather than from the outside. And so, he constructed all of the machinery and the software to create pleats from within". Hence, Miyake's pleats fold the inside outward and can thus be understood as *monadic,* with the *folds of the soul* materializing in the *pleats of matter.*

To expand upon this train of thought, Miyake's heritage and cultural background also feed into his unique design language, perspective, and aesthetic, and will be expanded upon in the following paragraph. As Tamara Tomić-Vajagić beautifully states in her study of the two colliding worlds between Issey Miyake and ballet choreographer William Forsythe: "Miyake's clothes are a conflux of contemporary aesthetic and innovation, of references to the designer's personal history – including traumatic sociopolitical realities of Hiroshima – as well as of cultural and historical contexts of draping and folding, including the kimono."[186] With this in mind, this last part of the chapter will examine the impact of the Japanese kimono on Miyake's work as well as introduce the concept of *ma*.

The Kimono, Flatness, and Ma

Although Miyake's fashion goes beyond the realm of merely being "Japanese" – also containing influences from America, France, and Britain – the threads of his garments nonetheless bear traces of his Japanese heritage. More specifically, his approach to fashion draws significant inspiration from the kimono and implements its traditional techniques of draping, wrapping, layering, and pleating.[187] With the envelopment of the body and the concurrent entrapment of space between fabric and flesh occupying a

[186] Tamara Tomić-Vajagić, "Shapeshifters and Colombe's Folds: Connective Affinities of Issey Miyake and William Forsythe," in *The Oxford Handbook of Contemporary Ballet*, eds. Kathrina Farrugia-Kriel and Jill Nunes Jensen (New York: Oxford University Press, 2021), 450f.
[187] English, *Japanese Fashion Designers*, 21.

central part of his work, his fashion becomes a material encounter with the concept of *ma*. The word can be roughly translated into "interval" or the "space in between" and in the context of the kimono, revolves around the space that is born when a body is wrapped in the garment.[188] The construction of the kimono is wide and flat, meaning that only once it is draped over the wearer's body, the garment transforms into a three-dimensional piece. The physical makeup of the body fills the flatness of the kimono, and the excess fabric creates drapes that fall straight over the body, subsequently cloaking its curves and proportions. Because the surplus of space between skin and fabric – the *ma* that is created in this process – does not adhere to the contours of the body, the kimono conjures a rather formless, baggy, and universal silhouette.[189] Thus, due to the simplistic and universal construction of the kimono, it is able to "package" any body, regardless of shape or gender.[190] In "refusing to use body-dimension as a point of departure", the kimono does not impose itself on the body, and it doesn't determine a fixed silhouette.[191] In contrast to traditional Western clothing, the principle of the kimono can liberate the body, not only in regard to granting it more "freedom", but also by visibly toning down the physical attributes that emphasize one's sex or body shape.[192]

Steering the discussion back to *ma* and its significance for Japanese (fashion) design, it carries a much more profound meaning than merely constituting the superfluous and relational space between different entities. Beyond moving within the realm of descriptive reality, it is also a subjective experience.[193] Exactly this fluidity of the concept enables it to break down rigid boundaries, whether they may be cultural,

---

[188] Koike, "3 – Developing Contemporaneity," 48.
[189] Akiko Fukai, ed., *Future Beauty: 30 Years of Japanese Fashion* (London: Merrell, 2010), 63.
[190] English, *Japanese Fashion Designers*, 21.
[191] "Dress Becomes Body: Fashioning the Force of Form," in *The Minor Gesture*, ed. Erin Manning (Durham: Duke University Press, 2016), 96.
[192] Although the kimono has been praised for offering a more fluid conception of fashion (see Fukai, *Future Beauty*; "Dress Becomes Body"; Richard Martin, "Our Kimono Mind: Reflections on 'Japanese Design: A Survey since 1950,'" in *Journal of Design History* vol. 8, no. 3 (January 1, 1995): 215–23; Kawamura, *The Japanese Revolution in Paris Fashion*.), it also actively reflects and reproduces traditional ideals of the model Japanese woman. As such, it can also be a very restrictive garment. (see Ofra Goldstein-Gidoni, "Fashioning Cultural Identity: Body and Dress," in *A Companion to the Anthropology of Japan*, ed. Jennifer Robertson (Oxford: Blackwell Publishing Ltd, 2005), 153–66; Lauren Prusinski, "Wabi-Sabi, Mono No Aware, and Ma: Tracing Traditional Japanese Aesthetics Through Japanese History," in *Studies on Asia* vol. 4, no. 2 (2012): 44.).
[193] Pilgrim, "Intervals ('Ma') in Space and Time," 255f.

temporal, or spatial.[194] *Ma* is dynamic, endlessly shaped by its environment, and operates at the intersection between boundaries. Consequently, it is a "rich space that possesses incalculable energy".[195] Due to its transcendent nature, it is hard to precisely pinpoint the role, function, and presence of *ma*. However, this is exactly where its beauty lies.[196] I would argue that by forcing us to acknowledge and experience the in-betweenness, the oscillation between rigid concepts, events, or things, *ma* is able to deconstruct rigid frames of mind as well as open oneself up to external forces. It constitutes the bridge between subject and object, raising our sensibility towards our situatedness and innately relational existence in the world. In Renske Maria van Dam's investigation of *ma* and movement, she concludes: "*Ma* is not just a gap between two doors; it is the change and movement, the energization happening within this gap."[197]

In a sartorial setting, *ma* intimately surrounds the body under the enveloping cloth. It is a lived phenomenon, the very interaction between wearer and garment. Bringing Miyake's pleats into play, *ma* occurs in a very responsive manner to both body and fabric. Similarly to the kimono, the flatness of Miyake's pleated garments requires a physical body to bring them to life.[198] In front of this, the body is the driving force that enables the garment to take on its final form and concurrently solicits the presence of *ma*.[199] Once draped on the body, Miyake's pleats inherently leave room for excess space, due to their folded texture, abstract silhouettes, and their lightweight yet quite stiff fabric that stays slightly suspended in space. Hence, the garments do not frame the body seamlessly, but always retain a slight amount of *ma*. Concurrently, the flexible and stretchy folds make his attire susceptible to the body's movements. *Ma* grows or shrinks in correspondence with the body in motion as well as the fluctuating polyester pleats it

---

[194] Prusinski, "Wabi-Sabi, Mono No Aware, and Ma," 29; Pilgrim, "Intervals ('Ma') in Space and Time," 256.
[195] Fukai, *Future Beauty*, 16.
[196] Prusinski, "Wabi-Sabi, Mono No Aware, and Ma," 29.
[197] Renske Maria van Dam, "Home Within Movement: The Japanese Concept of Ma (間): Sensing Space-Time Intensity in Aesthetics of Movement," in *Ancient and Modern Practices of Citizenship in Asia and the West: Care of the Self*, ed. Gregory Bracken (Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press, 2018), 250.
[198] Tomić-Vajagić, "Shapeshifters and Colombe's Folds: Connective Affinities of Issey Miyake and William Forsythe," 443; Fukai, *Future Beauty*, 16.
[199] In our interview, Ulrika emphasizes how Miyake's pleats are made for the "cultivated" Japanese woman, who, in contrast to Western conceptions of the body, does not perceive her body as "three-dimensional". Instead, she "move[s] in one piece" – her body is carefully articulated, still and composed, almost like a "paper doll". It appears she and Miyake's garments share a certain "flatness".

clings to, permitting high levels of flexibility and mobility.[200] It is consequently charged with the intensities, movements, and energies that emanate from its surrounding forces. Miyake's designs physically generate *ma*, but this "in-betweenness" also shows up within his overarching design concepts that question "binary oppositions between the past and the future, crafts and technology, tradition and avant-garde, East and West" and thus, frequently position fashion at various intersections, at the *ma* that occupies the space right between these boundaries.[201]



Figure 12:"Cicada" scarf transformed into a dress, Spring/Summer 1989.

This chapter has explored Issey Miyake's pleat along three different theoretical frameworks. Although fundamentally different from each other, these concepts have respectively enabled me to make the space between body and fold much more tangible.

[200] The pleat's facilitation of movement is further illustrated in Miyake's collaboration with choreographer William Forsythe (costumes for the ballet "The Loss of Small Detail", 1991) or his creation of the Lithuanian Olympic Team's uniform in 1992.
[201] Bartlett, "Issey Miyake," 224.

For instance, Merleau-Ponty's notion of *flesh* discusses the reversibility of being, the entanglement between body and world. In this sense, it fills the gap between internal and external and constitutes how they interact and relate to each other. In a similar vein, Deleuze brings to our attention the specific structure that lies within this interrelation between self and world and attributes it to the fold. Once different forces fold into each other, an *assemblage* transpires, subsequently leading to a *becoming*. Finally, under the notion of *ma,* we purposely linger between the boundaries of self and world, of skin and cloth. The liminal and indeterminate space in-between grants the body freedom as well as flexibility and can even open it up to a flux of energies and intensities that move outside of rigid borders.

As these reflections reveal, the relationship between flesh and fold can be considered as dynamically laden. However, as promising as the theoretical analysis of Miyake's pleat may be, it requires the complementary study of its lived experience. Only then are we able to move beyond the abstract, investigating if these findings are also grounded in reality. Thus, in the final chapter, the main focus lies on bridging theory and practice by examining a variety of personal experiences. Through interview excerpts, I aim to provide valuable insights into how my theoretical reflections may or may not translate into real life. Since this part will include subjective accounts from my interview partners and myself, it can only claim to explore a small fraction of the lived experience of Miyake's folded creations. Nonetheless, through a deep and thorough analysis of these limited materials, I intend to offer a profound glimpse into the embodied dimension of dress, and more specifically, Issey Miyake's pleated garments.

Chapter Three: Folded Experiences

This final chapter echoes Merleau-Ponty's plea for the study of the embodied, rendering dress as a "fleshy practice". [202] Using interviews, I will analyze the phenomenological implications of the pleat, as worn in everyday settings. I deem it crucial to acknowledge particularly those kinds of dress that are deeply ingrained into people's everyday lives. In alignment with Cheryl Buckley and Hazel Clark, who argue for the significance of mundane fashion practices, the shift towards the ordinary highlights an oftentimes overlooked or dismissed dimension of fashion and offers us a more profound glimpse into how the personal and social converge.[203] Combined with a phenomenological stance, the study of everyday dress can disclose how fashion inescapably permeates "our experience of the body and the ways in which the body can be used".[204] In light of this, I want to touch on Seely again, who discusses fashion's capability of transforming the body, although primarily in light of extraordinary examples of fashion. By affecting the body's senses and materiality, items of clothing can enter an intimate and even formative relationship with the body (an *assemblage*), which consequently opens it up to *becoming* and enables it to transcend normative binaries.[205]

With these three pillars in mind – the embodied, the everyday, and the transformative – I will conduct my investigation of Issey Miyake's pleats. I deem my positioning within these three aspects particularly productive, especially with respect to the power of the mundane. I would argue that the transformative dimension of fashion does not necessarily manifest in a body dressed in drastically bold designs on the runway. Instead, a discrete and more frequent occurrence of comparably subtle, yet nonetheless subversive dress in ordinary settings may lead to a more effective and rudimentary transformation of the self that also confronts hegemonic structures and norms. This is where Issey Miyake's pleats come into play. The fine folds and the flat construction of the garments frame the body in a rather sculptural manner, creating

---

[202] Joanne Entwistle and Elizabeth Wilson, "Introduction: Body Dressing," in *Body Dressing*, 4.
[203] Cheryl Buckley and Hazel Clark, "Conceptualizing Fashion in Everyday Lives," in *Design Issues* vol. 28, no. 4 (October 2012): 18–28.
[204] Paul Sweetman, "Shop-Window Dummies? Fashion, the Body, and Emergent Socialities," in *Body Dressing*, 66.
[205] Seely, "How Do You Dress a Body Without Organs?"

abstract silhouettes. Moreover, the pleated texture creates a mesmerizing effect, once the folds, set in motion by the moving body, fluidly capture shadow and light. At the same time, the pleats are quite uncomplicated and practical. Thus, they meet the needs of the everyday person and integrate seamlessly into the daily wardrobe.[206] As I will explore more in depth in this chapter, these aspects have also been alluded to in my interviews, with my participants expressing their appreciation for the pleat's versatility and easy incorporation into their day-to-day. For example, Edward (to be presented below) tells me: "It really stands out, and it's so extra. Yet it's so simple." Similarly, Louise (presented below) notes that: "It's not even a crazy piece, but it's just different, I would say." It could be argued that Miyake's pleats exist in the *ma* between effortless and elaborate, special and generic. By introducing "transseasonal, androgynous, and sculptural garments" to the Western fashion landscape, Miyake's fashion challenges those prevailing fashions that are often impractical, trend-oriented, figure-centric, or eroticized.[207]

In light of my prior analysis of the pleat's history and its theoretical significance, I will now explore how exactly body and fold interact with each other in the lived and experienced context. My motif lies in identifying if Miyake's pleat holds transgressive potential, whether it can transform one's body schema and break down the rigid walls of the normative structures that permeate the body in contemporary (Western) society. For this pursuit, I hope to provide a nuanced discussion by including eight different narratives. Before I introduce my interview partners, I want to acknowledge that their individual accounts are fundamentally impacted by their situatedness in the world – their bodily experience and awareness are culturally co-constructed.[208] The phenomenal body is innately embedded in the world, infused with normative values. Thus, when it comes to dressing, "sociological variables" continue to shape and influence one's choice of clothing.[209] In the same breath, fashion can additionally help "construct and reconstruct

---

[206] Quinn, *Techno Fashion*, 150.
[207] Vanessa Gerrie, *Borderless Fashion Practice: Contemporary Fashion in the Metamodern Age* (New Brunswick: Rutgers University Press, 2023), 59; Fred Davis, "Antifashion," in *Fashion Theory: A Reader*, ed. Barnard (London: Routledge, 2020), 82.
[208] Barnard, "Fashion, Clothes and the Body," in *Fashion Theory: A Reader*, ed. Barnard (London: Routledge, 2020), 465.
[209] Sweetman, "Shop-Window Dummies?," 66.

individual subjectivities" whilst also building a foundation for shared experiences and subjectivities between different actors.[210] In line with Merleau-Ponty's frame of thought, experience occurs reciprocally, meaning that "while experience is constituted by the social, it in turn effects and is capable of transforming the social".[211] Thus, with fashion right at the border between the self and the social, Miyake's pleats are not just limited to transforming the self, but can potentially set in motion a much more profound and expansive process of change and reconfiguration – a becoming that transpires beyond the self. Nevertheless, this chapter will primarily remain in the realm of the individual experience, as it cannot claim to make broader statements affecting wider society. In the following, I will give a brief overview of my interview partners and subsequently present my findings.

My Interview Partners

Lisa (she/her). Lisa is a 23-year-old student from Stockholm. I find her profile on TikTok, where she shares her passion and opinions revolving around fashion, including her appreciation for Issey Miyake. For our interview, we meet at a café in central Stockholm. As she takes off her long, black coat, my eyes meet her bright pink *Pleats Please* top.

Ruben (he/him). Ruben is 37 years old and a graphic designer based in Berlin. He tells me his first encounter with Issey Miyake was seeing actor Robin Williams wear a bomber jacket by the designer (AW1996) to a film premiere. Around six years ago, he started becoming fond of Miyake's pleats due to their versatility, adaptability, and comfort.

Louise (she/her). Louise is 25 years old and works as a social media officer for a Belgian fashion brand. Louise first encountered Issey Miyake on Tumblr more than 10 years ago. Our conversation includes reflections on her Miyake pieces in relation to body image, the history and ethos behind the brand, and its presence (or lack thereof) in real life vs. social media.

---

[210] Ibid., 73.
[211] Grosz, "Merleau-Ponty and Irigaray in the Flesh," 40.

Binta (she/her). Binta is 24 years old and studies in London. With scheduling issues ultimately prohibiting us from digitally talking face-to-face, Binta sends me her answers to my questions via Instagram direct message.

Edward (he/him). Edward is a 28-year-old graphic designer and photographer based in Manila. During our *Zoom* call, he guides me through his collection piece by piece and we relish in discussing the specificities of each item – its history, fit, and feel.

Ulrika (she/her). Ulrika is 50 years old and used to work for the Issey Miyake design studio *Reality Lab* as a textile designer. In our conversation on *Zoom*, she gives me insight into the processes behind the creations of the Issey Miyake house, as well as her reflections on being both a "sender" and a "receiver" of fashion.

Elisabet (she/her). Elisabet is 58 years old. She is an artist and a teacher with a background in fashion design, who is currently completing her PhD. Our interview was particularly insightful in light of Deleuze and the fold, since Elisabet's academic research places significant focus on his theories.

Tonie (she/her). Tonie is an 87-year-old Swedish costume historian, author, and fashion collector. In our interview over the phone, she opens up about her experiences of owning and wearing both Fortuny's *Delphos* dress as well as a couple of Issey Miyake pieces.

Findings

Through my eight interviews, which ranged from 30 minutes to one hour, my partners left me with valuable insights into several different aspects that play into the embodied experience of wearing Issey Miyake. In order to provide a clear and comprehensible structure for this analysis, I will organize my findings into these three overarching themes: aesthetics, feeling, and perception. Although these categories very fluidly meld into each other, I deem this division useful for the investigation of the visual, embodied, and reflective processes that play into lived experience.

Folded Aesthetic

As explored in the historical chapter, the pleat carries great significance due to its aesthetic function. It has been a recurring element in clothing design and the fine arts,

with folds creating a palpable texture that meticulously captures the contrast between light and shadow. Since Issey Miyake's pleats follow a predominantly simple and flat construction, the folds become one of the most striking features of the garment. This is not only attributed to the three-dimensional surface they create, but also to the structure and volume they provide. When asked what they found most appealing about Miyake's pleats, most of my interview partners pointed to the texture and structure of their Miyake items. For instance, Edward states:

> When I choose to wear an Issey Miyake piece, it's because I want to add a subtle touch of texture. The pleated design feels effortlessly refined – just the right amount of detail to complement my style without overwhelming it. […] It's chic. I'm not sure if many people appreciate pleated designs in clothing, but to me, it feels very graphic – almost like wearing a structural piece.

In terms of silhouette, Ruben emphasizes how the pleats allow him to experiment, stating that: "You can play so much with the shape. And, also, like I was saying, you can transform everything into different kind of pieces, so you can play a lot with volume, and shape in general." He appreciates their versatility, being able to combine or layer them in multiple ways, leading to the creation of a whole new look. To further illustrate, he tells me: "And then I use the long shirt as a skirt. Oh, that's so clever. Then it kinda gives a totally different vibe, and that's something that I kinda like that you can do with Issey, because those pieces are very easy to transform with something else." Here, similar to Deleuze's fold, the pleat acts in a very fluid manner, creating *assemblages* with other entities and as a result, reconfiguring itself in new ways.

At the same time, Ruben emphasizes their practicality. For him, the pleats are an effortless and universal piece of clothing, since they can be worn for any purpose: "[…] you don't have to think a lot about it. So I think that that's the beauty of Issey, like, you can use it for normal daily situations, like going to get groceries or just to go to work, whatever. But then you can also dress it up, like, if you go to a museum or a social occasion". This "easiness" of Miyake's pleats can also be identified in my interview with Louise, when she tells me that she finds Miyake's pleats to be quite basic, yet simultaneously elevated. Additionally, in relation to the way they look, she finds them

rather “accessible”, as they are not “super insane pieces” and the design “looks amazing on everyone”. Whenever she wears the pleat, she does not have to spend hours styling it. Instead, it facilitates the process of assembling an effortlessly stylish outfit. In a similar vein, Binta concludes her experience of wearing Miyake’s pleat as follows: “Usually when I decide to go out with an Issey piece I know that my outfit is going to be incredible. I don’t have a particular event. I really feel confident and especially observe when I have an Issey piece, it flatters me a lot.” The majority of my interview partners pointed to the subtle, yet elevated and functional design of Miyake’s folded creations, which has allowed them to seamlessly incorporate them into their wardrobe. When it comes to the look of Miyake’s pleats, most of my partners have had a predominantly positive opinion. However, Ulrika’s reflections particularly stand out, due to her unique perspective as both a designer and an “ordinary” woman. Hence, her attitude towards the pleat’s diverges: “from the designer perspective, it doesn't harmonize at all. And I think most women look ridiculous wearing pleats. But when it comes to me, the ordinary woman […] I like them. Because they are funny. They are very human. They are friendly, and they have this, you know, certain edge that gives the personality that little extra”.

Delving deeper into Miyake’s timeless aesthetic, especially in front of the contemporary fashion landscape characterized by a rapid overturn of trends, as well as anticipated changes in personal taste, Edward reflects: “[…] our style is ever evolving. Right? It's always changing. And I feel like I still carry it with me. You know, the pants that I bought, five, six years ago. I still carry it with me. I still use it. I can still use it on the daily yet casual or formal”. While Edward praises his Miyake items for having become staple pieces in his wardrobe, Louise discloses her struggle to balance her choice of dress with respect to social media and the perpetual introduction of new trends:

> But it's like trends come and go, and Issey Miyake is so timeless. It doesn't follow the trends. But when you're constantly on TikTok, when you're constantly on social media, you immediately get, like, affected by the trends. And then you start thinking about the timeless pieces that you have. Like, do they fit our current lifestyle? And I'm not sure if they do because everything's so trend-based, but they're timeless, you know, like, it shouldn't matter.

Reaffirming her decision not to feed into trends, Louise highlights that her Miyake pieces represent something deeper – a personal connection to the garment as well as a signifier of fashion history. This representational element could also be detected in the statements made by Lisa, Ruben, and Edward, as they acknowledge the historical dimension of Miyake's pleats. Beyond wearing his pieces just for their aesthetic, they are also a nod to his legacy as a designer. Thus, having their bodies draped in his pleats outwardly signals their affinity to his design philosophy and contribution to fashion history. In line with my discussion of the *monads* in the second chapter, by virtue of wearing Miyake's *pleats of matter,* one may also reflect his *folds of the soul.*

Feeling the Fold

In folding the experience of the pleat inward, we can more closely investigate the wearer's bodily engagement with Miyake's fashion and the emotions that arise in the process. My interviews provided me with an expansive amount of information about the sensitivities felt by the body enveloped in Miyake's pleats. Firstly, investigating the overarching theme of comfort, I received mixed impressions. For example, going back to Ulrika, she mentions a delay of movement within the garment: "It's like the material and the garment in full are behind me in every movement I do. If I lift my arm, I don't know if the garment follows me. I know it's probably there because it's the one certain situation, but I can't rely on it." She attributes the pleat's inability to follow the body to the distinct bodily demeanors between women from the East compared to the West. "Most Japanese women, they don't keep air in between their arms and torso. So, when they move, they move in one piece. […] Everything is very still. So, I think the pleats collection addresses a certain way of being, particularly connected to a female Japanese". Through this lens, the bodily behaviors of Japanese women serve to minimize and sustain the *ma* between skin and cloth, by omitting rash or highly expressive movements.

Tonie (see chapter 1) and Elisabet also find themselves in a quarrel with Miyake's pleats. As Elisabet says: "I don't like the material. […] I don't like synthetics. I understand why he is working with that, but I feel that they are dead. […] Maybe he's famous for that, but they are not comfortable to use. They are spectacular and behave in

a very interesting way with the forms, but from the perspective of sensing, there is not so much to get, I think". In reference to Merelau-Ponty, the polyester pleats can be said to inhibit Elisabet's being in the world, as they, from her point of view, cannot provide a rich sensorial experience. Instead, they impinge on her body's ability to encounter and to sense the external world to its fullest.

The feeling of the folded polyester fabric is also brought up by Edward when he explains that his movement in his pleated garments changed the more accustomed he became to them. Although he deems them very comfortable, he initially felt a heightened sense of awareness: "Before, the first time I'm wearing it, I'm very cautious and very careful because I might, you know, destroy it or whatever [..] But I realized, […] it's okay to move in it". Further reflecting on his current experience of wearing the pleats, he states: "every time I move, it just follows. Though it's not always perfect. I'm the kind of person who is, you know, […] I'm very all around, I'm very extroverted. So I don't really mind moving a lot with my pleated pieces. […] I don't act like 'oh, I don't have to move'."

While Lisa feels quite free within her airy Miyake pieces, she also admits to feeling uncomfortable at times, primarily attributed to how they increase her bodily silhouette and make her physically take up space. On one hand, this is exactly why she wears these pieces, as a tool that allows her to claim her space in the world. She brings up the example of choosing an outfit for her upcoming presentation at university, stating that: "Obviously, I have to wear a good outfit, just to get in the mental space. But then I thought, okay, if I wear an outfit that's considered loud, it doesn't have to be, like, loud in color, but kind of oversized. [...] But it can also be, like, in volume, shapes, movement". On the other hand, this increase in bodily dimension has also made her feel uncomfortable: "I did not find it flattering in the beginning, so I really had to challenge myself. […] You take up space in that garment. And I'm actually not very comfortable, being like, loud, I guess, in that way". This sense of "loudness", which stems from wearing rather "oversized" pieces of clothing, can be attributed to an influx of *ma* that is housed at the borders between the folded cloth and her skin.

Lisa's mixed feelings regarding her experience of wearing Miyake's pleat are also reflected in Louise's experience. When wearing her pieces, she feels more aware of her

body and its curves. Thus, when talking about a pleated dress she owns, she says: “At first, I felt awkward because it really follows your body, I guess. It's not like just a straight thing. It really follows your shapes.” Contrary to Lisa, Louise’s statements reveal that she feels as though the *ma* in her Miyake garments is uncomfortably too little, as the fabric sits too tight on her skin. In addition to the accentuation of her silhouette, she also mentions the thin material of one of her items:

> It really feels like you're kind of naked in a way, because it really accentuates your shapes in a way that you see your contours – but you're still covered, but you still feel kind of naked. […] Like, with my black top, for example, it’s not see-through at all, but then my beige dress kind of is a little bit, and you're like “I'm naked right now. People see me.”

Although the very thin and airy fabric makes her feel exposed at times, she also recognizes how light, unrestrictive, and adaptable it feels. Nonetheless, she believes Miyake’s folded pieces require some getting used to. In reference to her experience of feeling more “seen” in her pieces, she reflects: “And that's what's scary about it, but it's also, I think, what makes the pieces so beautiful. And it's just like the mental step you have to take. Like, am I ready or not to wear this piece? Am I gonna embody it? Is it gonna be flattering on me?” These reflections tempt me to refer back to Merleau-Ponty again, particularly with an eye to his core idea of bodily sensations being inherently connected to the mental state of a person. Louise’s account demonstrates how her bodily sensations stirred up a cognitive process that made her question the relationship between her body and the pleat.

Pleated Perceptions

In this last segment, I will explore how my interview partners reflect on their embodied experience of wearing Issey Miyake. This allows for an investigation of how their experiences are tied to, and are affected by the external world. Through my interviews, two particular aspects became crystallized: how the pleat enfolds feelings surrounding 1) body image and 2) gender identity. Although there have been dissimilarities within my interviewees’ accounts, I can conclude that in every case, Miyake’s pleat seems to

enter a distinct relationship with the fleshy body. Notably, his folded garments confront the materiality of the body – its shape and form as well as its gendered dimension. However, these aspects are inherently intertwined, as my discussion will show.

Taking a closer look at Ruben's narrative, he opens up to me about how the pleat has stuck with him, even throughout significant bodily changes. He gives me an example of a pair of pleated pants he bought when he was "a bit overweight". He initially found them appealing because their flowy and oversized silhouette slightly concealed his body shape. On the day of our interview, he even wears the same pair, as he feels like they still fit him properly. "Those pieces will, like, grow with you during the journey", he declares. However, he makes a distinction between his *Homme Pissé* and his *Pleats Please* pieces, saying that: "I felt that the men's line is more oversized, so it's easy to hide yourself in it. And the woman's line is more revealing, but, like, without being too sexy, just like you feel kind of sensual in it and also protected at the same time." [212] At this point, he feels that the *Pleats Please* pieces fit him better and are more flattering for his body. However, during the summer, when the body is usually covered in fewer layers and more skin is exposed, he admits to feeling a certain push to work out more, especially when he puts on his *Pleats Please* pieces. In this context, he says:

> I also think that working out is also connected with the way that I love to see my body during summer with the women's pleats. Because everything is kind of emphasized, right? And then I kinda feel that it gives some sort of extra volume. Like, it will always end up looking bigger. […] So I feel like, okay. I need to work out. I need to look good, especially with the pleats.

In a similar vein, Edward notes: "I mean, men are wearing *Pleats Please* now. […] And with muscular guys, it looks really good too. Like, the *Pleats Please*. It's super nice. I don't think they should have a distinction. I actually prefer *Pleats Please* over *Homme Plissé*". [213] Explaining his preference over the women's line, he traces it back to his slim

---

[212] *Homme Plissé* is Issey Miyake's pleated line for men, born in 2013. In contrast, *Pleats Please* is predominantly catered towards women. A few of my interview partners (male and female) own garments from both lines. However, the majority of my subjects own and wear items from the *Pleats Please* line.
[213] Ruben and Edward's emphasis on the pleat complementing particularly muscular bodies is reminiscent of the utilization of the pleat in Ancient Greek sculpture, where the folds served to accentuate the athletic, nude bodies of male figures.

body, which looks “almost like a female’s one”. What used to be an insecurity of his, he now embraces, as he feels like the *Pleats Please* pieces perfectly adapt to his body and “form” it really well.

The two different iterations of Miyake’s pleat have a fundamental impact on the relationship between body and fold, particularly in regard to gender. Reflections on the pleat as gendered also appear in my interview with Louise, who compares her experience of wearing a *Homme Plissé* jacket with her *Pleats Please* items:

> And then for my *Homme Plissé*, the men's jacket that I have, I sometimes feel like it's too manly for me. I love unisex clothes, and I feel like it's not really like, for men. I feel like Issey Miyake is often very unisex. But I still feel very manly when I wear that in contrast to when I wear the women's pleats, which makes me feel very womanly. But at the same time, I feel like I'm not a woman enough to wear it, if that makes sense. [..] mentally, I feel like I am not skinny enough. I'm not womanly enough or whatever to wear it.

When it comes to accentuating their female anatomy, Binta and Louise mention the pleat in light of how it lies over their breasts. Their choice not to wear a bra complicates their experience, as the pleat can draw attention to that part of their bodies. Binta states: “for women who do not wear a bra we are obliged to put a nipple cover on, otherwise it creates a different shape at the top”. Similarly, Louise mentions that “when I wear my Issey Miyake piece, I feel like I have to wear a bra because, otherwise, you're gonna see too much in a way. You don't see much, but, like, it feels like you see too much”. Hence, the delicate material and its fine folds seem to create a rather frail barrier between body and external world. In my discussion on the feminist reframings of phenomenology, the physical markers of gender, such as breasts, take up a crucial role. Louise and Binta’s experiences regarding their breasts as a part of their female anatomy can uniquely be attributed to their being in the world as women. Tied in with this are their anxieties about the presentation of their breasts – how the pleat may shape or reveal them in a way that may diverge from the normative ideals on how breasts ought to look in clothing.

For Lisa, her Miyake garments have played a fundamental role in reframing her outlook on her body, her femininity, and her presentation of self. In going from wearing

primarily tight-fitted garments to wearing looser styles, she was able to detach herself from “internalized ideas of how you should dress”. She tells me: “When I was, like, a teenager, I dressed very, very differently. Male gaze, if you will. And, honestly, it was subconscious, but also, like, conscious because my worth was kind of tied to my body, a lot. And I think that having pieces that are oversized, or the body not being a focus, was very healing for me, actually.” She has often encountered comments stating that Issey Miyake’s garments are unflattering because they are “not tight-fitting”, which she counters by questioning “But then why does everything have to be tight fitting for it to be flattering?” This ability of the pleat to decenter the body is also reflected in Edward’s account. He explains how, once worn, the folds can divert the attention from one’s body and its proportions to the garment that clothes it: “No matter your body type, I feel like people are not going to look at your body first. They're going to look into the piece that they're wearing.”

Regardless of the fact that my subjects have had both positive and negative experiences wearing the pleat, the vast majority acknowledge that it has ultimately impacted their outlook on themselves and their bodies, as well as how they encounter the world. While Ruben says that “It's a feeling, like, how clothes can make you change the way you see your body”, Louise notes, “Now it makes me really, like, accept my body in a way, if that makes sense.”

Having the ability to both hide and accentuate bodily contours or physical markers of gender, on one hand, Miyake’s pleats reiterate sartorial expectations connected to body shape and gender, and on the other, they can also offer grounds for a renegotiation of these bodily expectations. In my interviews, gender and body image were closely entangled with each other. For my subjects’ awareness of their self-presentation, the pleat could serve as a tool for comfort, releasing anxieties surrounding body image, or as a means to subvert the expectations placed on them. On the contrary, it also acted as a harsh reminder of their body’s physicality and brought forth a heightened feeling of insecurity and self-doubt. For some of my interview partners, they not only experienced an interplay of both, but the pleat also challenged their relationship with their bodies and ultimately transformed their outlook on themselves, their confidence, or their self-perception. This ties in beautifully with Deleuze’s conception of the pleat as a fluid,

dynamic and transformative force. Whether perceived in a positive or negative light, Miyake's fold had the ability to enter my subjects' *Baroque House* of self, ultimately folding into the upper chamber of their souls. The developments and changes that occurred in some of my partner's experiences throughout time and wear further highlight how the fold is an entity which endlessly folds into the self and vice versa, opening the body up to a perpetual *becoming.*

Discussion

This last section of the chapter analyzes my interview findings from a wider lens, taking into account the phenomenal body as embedded in the world. Not only is my aim to uncover those underlying structures and modes of thought that inherently impact one's lived experience, but also, in an attempt to discuss my findings from a more hopeful perspective, I will identify certain pockets of resistance and transformation that are caught between Miyake's folds.

First and foremost, my findings show that the "aesthetic" dimension of the pleat makes it easy to incorporate into the everyday wardrobe. Although it is an overarchingly simple piece of cloth, it nonetheless sets itself apart from ordinary clothing and exudes a sense of refinement. Because it is an uncomplicated and universal piece, the pleat seems to alleviate anxieties surrounding my interview partners' choice of dress, whether it be for everyday or more formal occasions. As Sophie Woodward observes in her study on women's sartorial choices, fashion can be used as a tool for creative expression, but can also become a source of panic. This panic is born from the amplified fragmentation of fashion trends in the modern fashion system, which creates ambiguity and uncertainty regarding which dress choices are accepted at a given time. In addition, societal expectations placed on the individual and their presentation of self add to the heightened awareness around one's external perception.[214] As Louise's self-questioning in regard to the rapid turnover of trends demonstrates, even a body clothed in Miyake's pleats, which have broadly been considered as "timeless" and "versatile", is susceptible to these emergent sartorial anxieties. Therefore, external pressures fundamentally play into the

[214] Sophie Woodward, *Why Women Wear What They Wear* (Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2007), 119.

process of dressing oneself. At the same time, clothing, considered the "medium through which women consider their social roles and normative ideals of how they should look", allows for a negotiation of the subject's position and identity in the world.[215]

In this regard, I am referring to Lucia Ruggerone, who expands on Woodward's intellectual conceptualization of dress by reading it through a Deleuzian lens, including its affective dimension.[216] To support her argumentation, Ruggerone presents a specific scenario, where a person may find a dress visually appealing, yet, once they try it on, it completely loses its appeal. From her perspective, this can be traced back to the very nature of sartorial encounters. Cloth and the body affect each other in unexpected and unforeseen ways, due to the garment invoking a process of the body in *becoming*.[217] This *assemblage* between body and cloth can defy all prior expectations, as it cannot be predicted and only experienced through their physical conglomeration. Such an event is also reflected in Tonie's statement, who explains how, although she initially was drawn to Miykae's garments for the way they looked, their actual embodied experience could not satisfy her in the slightest. In the event of her body meeting the garment, a *becoming* occurred that awoke unpleasant feelings in Tonie.

Taking a closer look at Lisa's account of wearing the pleat, there are noticeable developments in her experience. Admitting to an initially heightened sense of discomfort, she has now grown more accustomed to the way her body and the cloth engage with each other. She "challenged" herself by repeatedly opening her body up to a *becoming* with the garment, despite her feelings of unease at the beginning. Additionally, she began to question the patriarchal ideals she had internalized and deliberately began to use the discomfort she experienced in Miyake's garments as a way to actively protest and transgress them. Due to the extra room for air between body and flesh (the *ma*), they allow her to physically take up space, as well as avert the focus away from her body. She explains how this stands in contrast to how she used to dress in tight-fitting styles informed by the "male gaze". Taking Sandra Lee Bartky's exploration of women's bodily behavior into account, Bartky notes that the ideal female body is a

---

[215] Ibid., 69.
[216] Ruggerone, "The Feeling of Being Dressed," 582.
[217] Ibid., 582 and 584.

socially constructed body, a "body on which an inferior status has been inscribed".[218] This is reflected in female bodily behaviors and the stylization of the female body. She observes how women's bodies comport themselves in public, as captured in photographs by Marianne Wex. Compared to men's bodies, they take up minimal space and keep their bodies composed in a rather compact and composed manner.[219] This aspect is also referenced in Ulrika's statements, when she notes how the pleat particularly addresses Japanese women's modalities of bodily comportment, which are quite still and confined.

Iris Marion Young takes up the modalities of women's movement and spatiality, posing the argument that "patriarchal society defines woman as object, as a mere body".[220] Consequently, since a woman's body is the "object of the gaze of another", it becomes a "thing" that she monitors and performs from a disconnected stance.[221] Tying this back to Bartky, femininity is a disciplinary project of bodily transformation that women are ultimately destined to fail.[222] Introducing a wide range of areas she needs to police, she explores how women take up as little space as possible in the world, not only in regard to constraints within her movements and body language, but also in terms of her body size. This minimization of her physical presence signals her subordinate role in patriarchal society, or, in other words, the dominance of men.[223] Since more curvaceous bodies are regarded as "distasteful", women are expected to maintain an infantilized body, one that is rather frail, small, and immature.[224] Traces of these expectations towards women are mirrored in Louise's statements, when she mentions how the pleat exposes and accentuates her curves and consequently, makes her feel self-conscious. In line with this, she admits that she doesn't feel "womanly" and "skinny" enough for her *Pleats Please* items.

---

[218] Sandra Lee Bartky, "Foucault, Femininity, and the Modernization of Patriarchal Power," in *The Politics of Women's Bodies: Sexuality, Appearance, and Behavior*, eds. Rose Weitz and Samantha Kwan (New York: Oxford University Press, 2014), 73.
[219] Ibid., 70.
[220] Iris Marion Young, "Throwing Like a Girl: A Phenomenology of Feminine Body Comportment, Motility and Spatiality," in *On Female Body Experience: Throwing Like a Girl and Other Essays* (Oxford, USA: Oxford University Press, Incorporated, 2005), 44.
[221] Ibid., 39.
[222] Bartky, "Foucault, Femininity, and the Modernization of Patriarchal Power," 74.
[223] Ibid., 76.
[224] Ibid., 75.

The discomfort both Louise and Binta express in relation to how the folds drape over their breasts when not wearing a bra leads me back to Young, who points to the significance of breasts for women's lived experiences.[225] Binta discusses the issue of her nipples becoming particularly visible, which forces her to wear nipple covers. She attributes this to the "different shape" the pleat creates, although it could be argued that Binta's breasted experience can to some extent also be linked to patriarchal expectations, since Young remarks that "Nipples are no-nos, for they show the breasts to be active and independent zones of sensitivity and eroticism."[226] In the context of female experience, Luna Dolezal posits how women's bodies are "already shame-prone as a result of their cultural inheritance", referring to the normative body ideals they are subjected to.[227] Since Miyake's pleats have the power to present the natural body more visibly, feelings of shame and a heightened self-awareness arise. In the case of breasts, which Young considers "the symbol of feminine sexuality", these sensations may be even more pronounced.[228]

Nonetheless, normative ideals on how bodies should look also materialize in Ruben's and Edward's narratives. In contrast to the cultural pressure for women to occupy a minimal amount of space, traditional ideals of masculinity expect the opposite, i.e., tall and strong bodies.[229] This is reflected in how both of my interview partners point to how *Pleats Please* complements particularly muscular body types. To expand on this, both have told me about how male body ideals have affected their feelings and sartorial practices. In this regard, the pleat has had ambiguous functions – the *Homme Plissé* pants veiled Ruben's body proportions when he was a bigger size, whereas his *Pleats Please* pieces feel more flattering to his current body type and animate him to physically "improve" his shape. Edward prefers the *Pleats Please* range, since it molds perfectly to his slender, more "feminine" body, which he now embraces. Both of them appreciate

---

[225] Young, "Breasted Experience: The Look and the Feeling," in *On Female Body Experience,* 75–96.
[226] Ibid., 84.
[227] Luna Dolezal, *Body and Shame: Phenomenology, Feminism, and the Socially Shaped Body* (Lanham, London: Lexington Books, 2015), 109.
[228] Young, "Breasted Experience: The Look and the Feeling," 77.
[229] Jay McCauley Bowstead, "Body Language: Toward a Phenomenology of Masculinity," in *Menswear Revolution: The Transformation of Contemporary Men's Fashion* (London: Bloomsbury Visual Arts, 2018), 99.

the sensual and softer characteristics of the women's line, which, in their case, either serves to accentuate a stereotypically masculine body or to embrace feminine features, both in terms of body shape (Edward) or style (Ruben).

Although the inclusion of traditionally "feminine" features in male dress may subvert gender norms, Llewellyn Negrin argues that "the postmodern play with gender" does not hold the power to fully transcend gender binaries, but rather acts as a means for a "renegotiation of those boundaries".[230] Taking this one step further, Ruth Holliday argues that rejections of hegemonic discourses can feed into personal comfort, which in turn is closely linked to identity and feelings of authenticity.[231] In the case of Miyake's pleat, it prioritizes function over aesthetics, liberating its subject from societal constraints.[232] The comfort that unfolds is not always instantaneous, with multiple of my interview partners describing how the feel and experience of their folded garments changed throughout continuous wear. The pleat has even been able to transform their gendered subjectivities, ultimately impacting bodily practices and perceptions of self. The pleat may only hold power to "renegotiate" gendered binaries from an exterior stance, but on a deeply intrinsic level, it can transform the individual by introducing "alternative modes of being, acting, and living", as demonstrated in Lisa's account for instance.[233] In this regard, Holliday states: "If femininity is imposed by patriarchal culture and is socially constructed, then it can be changed or at least resisted."[234] Through wearing Miyake's pleated garments, Lisa can actively claim her existence as a woman in the world, using the fold to reconceptualize her body's capacities within patriarchal society and transgressing restrictive gender boundaries.

Concludingly, as my discussion suggests, Miyake's pleats enfold a "contextual flexibility", meaning that they easily integrate and adapt into different settings and corporealities whilst simultaneously presenting "multiple opportunities for exploring

---

[230] Negrin, *Appearance and Identity* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan US, 2008), 140.
[231] Ruth Holliday, "Fashioning the Queer Self," in *Body Dressing*, 220.
[232] In the case of women, this also expands to the physically restrictive types of dress that pervade female sartorial conventions.
[233] Seely, "How Do You Dress a Body Without Organs?," 263.
[234] Ruth Holliday, "Fashioning the Queer Self," 220.

various subject positions".[235] Although the *Homme Plissé* and *Pleats Please* lines each target a certain gender, the pleat's flat, simple, and pliable construction offers a more liberated and universal approach to dress, moving more fluidly in-between these binaries. Tying this to Deleuze, it can not only fold *over*, but it also fold *into* any body. A bilateral transformation occurs, with the folded garment adapting to the unique corporeality of its wearer, and the wearer's body opening up to a *becoming*. In reference to the Baroque House, the material pleat can be said to enter the *folds of the soul* in the upper chamber. This intimate and reciprocal relationship between body and fold is reflected in the sometimes conflicting experiences of my interview partners, as their individual physicalities and demeanors engage uniquely with the pleat.

As established in my discussion of Merleau-Ponty, bodies are inevitably enmeshed with the *flesh* of the world and thus, permeated by normative discourses on dress, body image, and gender. In some cases, Miyake's garments have confronted my interview partners with their perceived bodily "deficiencies". Through this, they were also utilized as a means to accept, embrace, or even reinforce exactly these bodily materialities, behaviors, or stylizations that deviate from such conventions. In these instances, the fold has led to a "deterritorialization by which one leaves the familiar terrain of idealized body shapes, unified wholes or fixed structures".[236] Miyake's pleats fold into the lived reality of the body they drape, mediating its existence in the world as well as opening it up to a *becoming.* Concurrently, the folds harness transformative power, although unfolding rather subtly and increasing in magnitude throughout repeated encounters with the body. Ultimately, by enfolding modes of being that offer pockets of resistance towards dominating social structures, Miyake's folded fashion may even enable a transgression of fixed and rigid boundaries, specifically pertaining to gendered embodiment.

---

[235] Susan Kaiser, "Minding Appearances: Style, Truth, and Subjectivity," in *Body Dressing*, 87.
[236] Smelik, "Fashioning the Fold," 51.

Conclusion

Due to its fluid, unconfined, and pliable nature, the fold is a phenomenon that is difficult to grasp. Nonetheless, this thesis has attempted to unfold its affective power, discovering what transpires once the fold, as manifested in Issey Miyake's pleats, and the human body converge. Guided by Merleau-Ponty and Deleuze, I have sought to capture this "in-betweenness" of the fold, as well as consider its transformative capacity. As the three chapters highlight from different angles, the pleat and the body engage in an intimate and reciprocal relationship. The flat garment is filled with the physical body of the wearer, which breathes life into the frozen folds and initiates a flow of "folding, unfolding, refolding".[237] My research inquiry was more specifically focused on how the pleat folds into the embodied reality of its host and subsequently opens their body up to a *becoming.* Through a Deleuzian reading of the pleat, a process of transformation ensues in consequence. Moreover, we are presented with the prospect of a transgression of fixed boundaries, which I have further explored through interviews. The phenomenal body, always embedded in its situational and timely context, is involuntarily subjected to specific norms. Looking at the gendered body in particular, it is categorized within a binary system that imposes specific regulations. As my analysis of the lived experience of wearing the pleat suggests, a body enveloped in pleats either brings these social and cultural implications to the forefront or can resist them by introducing an alternative approach to the stylization, comportment, and sensory experience of the body in the world.

Unfolding the pleat throughout history, chapter one has revealed the different ways the fold has been implemented in fashion. By taking a closer look at the different materials, construction techniques of the pleat, as well as the specific socio-cultural norms it has been embedded in, I was able to provide a glimpse into how the pleat's implication for embodied experience has shifted and transformed in time.

The second chapter has introduced the theoretical concepts of Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology, Deleuze's fold and the Japanese *ma*. Along these theories, I have inspected Issey Miyake's folded garments and emphasized their philosophical

[237] Deleuze, *The Fold*, 158.

significance. The space between fold and skin has been conceptualized as a powerful force that invites a dynamic understanding of the body's capacities and its reciprocal relationship with external entities.

This theoretical discussion has built the foundation for the final chapter, which has set out to translate the theoretical into the practical. Semi-structured interviews with eight individuals provided me with insight into the embodied experience of wearing Miyake's pleated fashion. The results were at times ambiguous and presented very varying levels of "transformation", which subsequently solidifies the elusive essence of the fold. Moreover, the *assemblage* between the individual and the pleat does not follow a predetermined pattern, but instead, expresses itself in unique ways. Nonetheless, my findings elaborate on how the pleat folds into diverse aspects of experience, predominantly looks and aesthetics, its haptic and emotional reception, as well as the reflective processes it sets in motion.

This thesis has concerned itself with a widely underrepresented aspect of research within fashion studies, namely the phenomenal experience of clothing. By including a historical, theoretical, and embodied study of the pleat, I was able to merge different perspectives, thus offering a multifaceted study of the pleat and how it affects the body it drapes. This endeavor stands in opposition to the traditional, disembodied research approach towards dress, which dismisses the role of the lived, experienced, and sensuous body. In Western epistemology, fashion has been primarily explored as a textual or semiotic phenomenon.[238] Hence, in regard to its symbolic meaning, it is understood as a merely communicative and representative medium, stripped of its materiality and corporeality. This gap within fashion research is what I intended to at least marginally fill with my project. Nonetheless, I believe the non-representational dimension of fashion deserves more scholarly attention in the future, as it can provide greater insights into how items of fashion can affect living bodies and even become a tool to transform normative ways of being. Through this, we may even be able to identify its emancipatory potential, opening doors for a transgression of oppressive boundaries.

[238] Sweetman, "Shop-Window Dummies?," 60.

Bibliography

Ahmed, Sara. *Queer Phenomenology: Orientations, Objects, Others*. Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press, 2006.

Barnard, Malcom. "Fashion, Clothes and the Body." In *Fashion Theory: A Reader*, edited by Malcolm Barnard, 461–76. London: Routledge, 2020.

Bartky, Sandra Lee. "Foucault, Femininity, and the Modernization of Patriarchal Power." In *The Politics of Women's Bodies: Sexuality, Appearance, and Behavior*, edited by Rose Weitz and Samantha Kwan, Fourth edition, 64–85. New York: Oxford University Press, 2014.

———. "Narcissism, Femininity and Alienation." In *Fashion Theory*, edited by Malcom Barnard, Second edition, 677–91. London: Routledge, 2020.

Bartlett, Djurdja. "Issey Miyake: Making Things." In *Fashion Theory* vol. 4, no. 2 (May 2000): 223–27.

Belk, Russell W. "Possessions and the Extended Self." In *Journal of Consumer Research* vol. 15, no. 2 (September 1, 1988): 139–68.

Bowker, Geoffrey C. "A Plea for Pleats." In *Deleuzian Intersections: Science, Technology, Anthropology*, edited by Casper Bruun Jensen and Kjetil Rödje, 123–38. New York, Oxford: Berghahn Books, 2009.

Bowstead, Jay McCauley. "Body Language: Toward a Phenomenology of Masculinity." In *Menswear Revolution: The Transformation of Contemporary Men's Fashion*, First edition, 71–110. London: Bloomsbury Visual Arts, 2018.

"Breasted Experience: The Look and the Feeling." In *On Female Body Experience: Throwing Like a Girl and Other Essays*, 75–96. Oxford, USA: Oxford University Press, Incorporated, 2005.

Breward, Christopher. *Fashion*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003.

Bruno, Giuliana. "Pleats of Matter, Folds of the Soul." In *Afterimages of Gilles Deleuze's Film Philosophy*, edited by D. N. Rodowick, 213–33. Minneapolis, London: University of Minnesota Press, 2009.

Buckley, Cheryl, and Hazel Clark. "Conceptualizing Fashion in Everyday Lives." In *Design Issues* vol. 28, no. 4 (October 2012): 18–28.

Butler, Judith. “Performative Acts and Gender Constitution: An Essay in Phenomenology and Feminist Theory.” In *Theatre Journal* vol. 40, no. 4 (1988): 519–31.

———. “Sexual Difference as a Question of Ethics: Alterities of the Flesh in Irigaray and Merleau-Ponty.” In *Senses of the Subject*, 149–70. New York, USA: Fordham University Press, 2015.

———. “Sexual Ideology and Phenomenological Description: A Feminist Critique of Merleau-Ponty’s Phenomenology of Perception.” In *The Thinking Muse: Feminism and Modern French Philosophy*, edited by Jeffner Allen and Marion Young, 85–100. Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1989.

Chen, Jing, and Yiqiang Cao. “Research on the Drapery in Ancient Greek Sculptures.” In *Asian Social Science* vol. 17, no. 6 (May 31, 2021): 29–37.

Chen, Mel Y. *Animacies: Biopolitics, Racial Mattering, and Queer Affect*. Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press, 2012.

Cleland, Liza, Glenys Davies, and Lloyd Llewellyn-Jones. *Greek and Roman Dress from A to Z*. London, New York: Routledge, 2007.

Conley, Tom. “Fifteen: Folds and Folding.” In *Gilles Deleuze: Key Concepts*, edited by Charles J. Stivale, Second Edition, 192–203. Oxon: Routledge, 2014.

Davis, Fred. “Antifashion.” In *Fashion Theory: A Reader*, edited by Malcolm Barnard, 78–91. London: Routledge, 2020.

Deleuze, Gilles. *Difference and Repetition*. Translated by Paul Patton. New York: Columbia University Press, 1994.

———. *The Fold: Leibniz and the Baroque*. Translated by Tom Conley. London: Continuum International Publishing Group, 2006.

Deleuze, Gilles, and Félix Guattari. *A Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia*. Translated by Brian Massumi. Minneapolis, London: University of Minnesota Press, 1987.

Dolezal, Luna. *Body and Shame: Phenomenology, Feminism, and the Socially Shaped Body*. Lanham, London: Lexington Books, 2015.

Eckersley, Andrea, and Cameron Duff. “Bodies of Fashion and the Fashioning of Subjectivity.” In *Body & Society* vol. 26, no. 4 (December 2020): 35–61.

English, Bonnie. *Japanese Fashion Designers: The Work and Influence of Issey Miyake, Yohji Yamamoto and Rei Kawakubo*. New York: Berg Publishers, 2011.

———. "Sartorial Deconstruction: The Nature of Conceptualism in Postmodernist Japanese Fashion Design." In *The International Journal of the Humanities: Annual Review* vol. 9, no. 2 (2011): 81–86.

Entwistle, Joanne. "Fashion and the Fleshy Body: Dress as Embodied Practice." In *Fashion Theory* vol. 4, no. 3 (August 2000): 323–47.

———. "The Dressed Body." In *Body Dressing: Dress, Body, Culture*, edited by Joanne Entwistle and Elizabeth Wilson, First edition, 33–58. Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2001.

———. *The Fashioned Body: Fashion, Dress and Modern Social Theory*. Third edition, Cambridge: Polity Press, 2023.

Entwistle, Joanne, and Elizabeth Wilson. "Introduction: Body Dressing." In *Body Dressing: Dress, Body, Culture*, edited by Joanne Entwistle and Elizabeth Wilson, First edition, 1–10. Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2001.

Farinelli, Virginia, Laura Falchi, Cristina Da Roit, Margherita Gnemmi, and Francesca Caterina Izzo. "Unveiling Polychrome Printing Methods on Textiles: Preliminary Results from the Mariano Fortuny y Madrazo Collection in Venice." In *Heritage* vol. 7, no. 3 (March 1, 2024): 1298–1319.

Frankel, Susannah. "Flatness." In *Future Beauty: 30 Years of Japanese Fashion*, by Akiko Fukai, 63–84. London: Merrell, 2010.

Franklin, Marianne. *Understanding Research: Coping with the Quantitative - Qualitative Divide*. New York: Routledge, 2012.

Fukai, Akiko, ed. *Fashion: Eine Modegeschichte Vom 18. Bis 20. Jahrhundert*. Köln: Taschen GmbH, 2015.

———, ed. *Future Beauty: 30 Years of Japanese Fashion*. London: Merrell, 2010.

Galczynski, Jordan, and Robyn Price. "Fashioning Sensescapes through Ancient Egyptian Dance." In *Textiles in Motion: Dress for Dance in the Ancient World*, edited by Audrey Gouy, 119–39. Oxford and Philadelphia: Oxbow Books, 2024.

Gerrie, Vanessa. *Borderless Fashion Practice: Contemporary Fashion in the Metamodern Age*. New Brunswick: Rutgers University Press, 2023.

Goldstein-Gidoni, Ofra. “Fashioning Cultural Identity: Body and Dress.” In *A Companion to the Anthropology of Japan*, edited by Jennifer Robertson, 153–66. Malden, Oxford, Victoria: Blackwell Publishing Ltd, 2005.

Grömer, Karina, and Antoinette Rast-Eicher. “To Pleat or Not to Pleat – An Early History of Creating Three-Dimensional Linear Textile Structures.” In *Annalen Des Naturhistorischen Museums in Wien. Serie A Für Mineralogie Und Petrographie, Geologie Und Paläontologie, Anthropologie Und Prähistorie* vol. 121 (2019): 83–112.

Grosz, Elizabeth. “Merleau-Ponty and Irigaray in the Flesh.” In *Thesis Eleven* vol. 36, no. 1 (August 1993): 37–59.

———. *Volatile Bodies: Toward a Corporeal Feminism*. Bloomington and Indianapolis: Indiana University Press, 1994.

Heinämaa, Sara. *Toward a Phenomenology of Sexual Difference: Husserl, Merleau-Ponty, Beauvoir*. Lanham, Md.: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2003.

Hollander, Anne. *Seeing Through Clothes*. New York: Avon Books, 1978.

Holliday, Ruth. “Fashioning the Queer Self.” In *Body Dressing: Dress, Body, Culture*, edited by Joanne Entwistle and Elizabeth Wilson, First edition, 215–32. Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2001.

Howell, Kerry E. *An Introduction to the Philosophy of Methodology*. Los Angeles: SAGE, 2016.

Huang, Tsai-Chun. “In-Between Pleats: Pleats, Pleating and ‘Pliable Logic.’” Ph.D., Royal College of Art, 2020.

———. “Pliable Logic as a Practice-Led Research Methodology for Textile Practice.” *TEXTILE* vol. 22, no. 1 (January 2, 2024): 142–57.

Irigaray, Luce. *An Ethics of Sexual Difference*. London: Athlone, 1993.

Jansen, Julia, and Maren Wehrle. “The Normal Body: Female Bodies in Changing Contexts of Normalization and Optimization.” In *New Feminist Perspectives on Embodiment*, edited by Clara Fischer and Luna Dolezal, 37–55. Cham: Springer International Publishing, 2018.

Johnstone, Janet M. “Wrapping and Tying Ancient Egyptian New Kingdom Dresses.” In *Wrapping and Unwrapping Material Culture*, edited by Susanna Harris and Laurence Douny, First edition, 59–82. London, New York: Routledge, 2016.

Jones, Jana. “The Enigma of the Pleated Dress: New Insights from Early Dynastic Helwan Reliefs.” In *The Journal of Egyptian Archaeology* vol. 100, no. 1 (January 2014): 209–31.

Kaiser, Susan. “Minding Appearances: Style, Truth, and Subjectivity.” In *Body Dressing: Dress, Body, Culture*, edited by Joanne Entwistle and Elizabeth Wilson, First edition, 79–102. Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2001.

Kanda, L. Leann. “Under Tension, Under Pressure, Making Waves: Reconstructing the Historic Fortuny Delphos Pleats.” In *Dress* vol. 50, no. 1 (January 2, 2024): 81–100.

Kawamura, Yuniya. *The Japanese Revolution in Paris Fashion*. Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2004.

Kearney, Kathleen. “Mariano Fortuny’s Delphos Robe: Some Possible Methods of Pleating and the Permanence of the Pleats.” In *Clothing and Textiles Research Journal* vol. 10, no. 3 (March 1992): 86–91.

Kitamura, Midori, ed. *Issey Miyake*. Cologne: Taschen, 2024.

Koike, Kazuko. “3 – Developing Contemporaneity.” In *Issey Miyake*, edited by Midori Kitamura, 48–53. Cologne: Taschen, 2024.

Lalloo-Morar, Sandhya. “Design Innovation by Japanese Designers Miyake, Kawakubo, and Yamamoto.” In *Berg Encyclopedia of World Dress and Fashion: East Asia*, edited by John E. Vollmer, First edition, vol. 6., Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2010.

Laver, James. *Costume and Fashion: A Concise History*. Sixth edition, New York: Thames & Hudson Inc., 2020.

Lee, Mireille M. *Body, Dress, and Identity in Ancient Greece*. New York: Cambridge University Press, 2015.

Livesey, Graham. “Assemblage.” In *The Deleuze Dictionary Revised Edition*, edited by Adrian Parr, 18–19. Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2010.

Loscialpo, Flavia. “Fashion and Philosophical Deconstruction: A Fashion In-Deconstruction.” In *Fashion Forward*, edited by Alissa De Wit-Paul and Mira Crouch, 13–27. Oxford: BRILL, 2011.

———. “The Fashion Revolution of Avant-Garde Japanese Designers: Issey Miyake, Rei Kawakubo, Yohji Yamamoto.” In *Fashion-Wise*, edited by Maria Vaccarella and Jacquelyn Foltyn, 21–32. Leiden, The Netherlands: BRILL, 2013.

Manning, Erin, ed. “Dress Becomes Body: Fashioning the Force of Form.” In *The Minor Gesture*. Durham: Duke University Press, 2016.

Marra-Alvarez, Melissa. “When the West Wore East: Rei Kawakubo, Yohji Yamamoto and The Rise of the Japanese Avant-Garde in Fashion.” In *Kyoto Costume Institute* 57 (2010).

Martin, Richard. “Our Kimono Mind: Reflections on ‘Japanese Design: A Survey since 1950.’” In *Journal of Design History* vol. 8, no. 3 (January 1, 1995): 215–23.

Mears, Patricia. “Formalism and Revolution: Rei Kawakubo and Yohji Yamamoto.” In *Japan Fashion Now*, edited by Valerie Steele, 141–208. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2010.

Merleau-Ponty, Maurice. *Phenomenology of Perception*. Translated by Donald Landes. First edition, London: Routledge, 2010.

———. *The Primacy of Perception: And Other Essays on Phenomenological Psychology, the Philosophy of Art, History and Politics*. Edited by James M. Edie. Evanston, Illinois: Northwestern University Press, 1964.

———. *The Visible and the Invisible: Followed by Working Notes*. Evanston, Illinois: Northwestern University Press, 1968.

Morgado-Roncal, Leyre, Juliane Müller, and Marisa Kerbizi. “Towards Textile Narratives: A Cross-Over Perspective on Textile Imagery in Statuary, Iconography, and Literature.” In *Textile Crossroads: Exploring European Clothing, Identity, and Culture across Millennia* vol. 10 (2024).

Muñoz, Marta, and Ángel Cordero. “The Fold as a Design Strategy: Analogy between Architecture and Issey Miyake’s Work.” In *Arts* vol. 13, no. 5 (September 23, 2024): 144.

Negrin, Llewellyn. *Appearance and Identity*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan US, 2008.

———. “Maurice Merleau-Ponty: The Corporeal Experience of Fashion.” In *Thinking Through Fashion: A Guide to Key Theorists*, edited by Agnès Rocamora and Anneke Smelik, First edition, 115–31. London: I.B. Tauris, 2019.

Olkowski, Dorothea, and Gail Weiss. *Feminist Interpretations of Maurice Merleau-Ponty*. University Park, Pa.: Pennsylvania State University Press, 2006.

O’Sullivan, Simon. *Art Encounters Deleuze and Guattari*. London: Palgrave Macmillan UK, 2006.

Paul, Jackson. *Complete Pleats: Pleating Techniques for Fashion, Architecture, Design.* London: Laurence King Publishing, 2015.

Peck, William H. *The Material World of Ancient Egypt*. First edition, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013.

Pilgrim, Richard B. “Intervals (‘Ma’) in Space and Time: Foundations for a Religio-Aesthetic Paradigm in Japan.” In *History of Religions* vol. 25, no. 3 (February 1986): 255–77.

Polan, Brenda, and Roger Tredre. *The Great Fashion Designers*. Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2009.

Prusinski, Lauren. “Wabi-Sabi, Mono No Aware, and Ma: Tracing Traditional Japanese Aesthetics Through Japanese History.” In *Studies on Asia* vol. 4, no. 2 (2012).

Quinn, Bradley. *Techno Fashion*. Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2002.

Riggs, Christina. *Unwrapping Ancient Egypt: The Shroud, The Secret and The Sacred*. London, New York: Bloomsbury Academic, 2014.

Ruggerone, Lucia. “The Feeling of Being Dressed: Affect Studies and the Clothed Body.” In *Fashion Theory* vol. 21, no. 5 (September 3, 2017): 573–93.

Rzepka, Slawomir. “Reconstruction of the Kilt Represented on a Statue of Neferefre.” In *The Journal of Egyptian Archealogy* vol. 86 (2000).

Seely, Stephen D. “How Do You Dress a Body Without Organs?: Affective Fashion and Nonhuman Becoming.” In *WSQ: Women’s Studies Quarterly* vol. 41, no. 1–2 (March 2013): 247–65.

Smelik, Anneke. “Fashioning the Fold: Multiple Becomings.” In *This Deleuzian Century: Art, Activism, Life*, by Rosi Braidotti and Rick Dolphijn, 37–56. Leiden and Boston: BRILL, 2014.

———. “Gilles Deleuze: Bodies-without-Organs in the Folds of Fashion.” In *Thinking Through Fashion: A Guide to Key Theorists*, edited by Agnès Rocamora and Anneke Smelik, First edition, 165–83. London, England: I.B. Tauris, 2019.

———. “New Materialism: A Theoretical Framework for Fashion in the Age of Technological Innovation.” In *International Journal of Fashion Studies* vol. 5, no. 1 (April 1, 2018): 33–54.

Smith, Wendy Ligon. *Fortuny: Time, Space, Light*. New Haven and London: Yale University Press, 2022.

Spantidaki, Stella. “The Embellishment Techniques of Classical Greek Textiles.” In *Greek and Roman Textiles and Dress: An Interdisciplinary Anthology*, edited by Mary Harlow and Marie-Louise Nosch, 34–45. Oxford and Philadelphia: Oxbow Books, 2014.

Sparks, Diane. “Explorations In Pleated Fabric Garment Structures.” In *Clothing and Textiles Research Journal* vol. 22, no. 1–2 (2004): 38–43.

Stoller, Silvia. “Asymmetrical Genders: Phenomenological Reflections on Sexual Difference.” In *Hypatia* vol. 20, no. 2 (2005): 7–26.

Sweetman, Paul. “Shop-Window Dummies? Fashion, the Body, and Emergent Socialities.” In *Body Dressing: Dress, Body, Culture*, edited by Joanne Entwistle and Elizabeth Wilson, First edition, 59–78. Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2001.

Thanem, Torkild, and David Knights. *Embodied Research Methods*. London: SAGE Publications, Ltd, 2019.

“Throwing Like a Girl: A Phenomenology of Feminine Body Comportment, Motility and Spatiality.” In *On Female Body Experience: Throwing Like a Girl and Other Essays*, 27–45. Oxford, USA: Oxford University Press, Incorporated, 2005.

Tomić-Vajagić, Tamara. “Shapeshifters and Colombe’s Folds: Connective Affinities of Issey Miyake and William Forsythe.” In *The Oxford Handbook of Contemporary Ballet*, edited by Kathrina Farrugia-Kriel and Jill Nunes Jensen. Oxford Handbooks Online. New York: Oxford University Press, 2021.

Tracy, Sarah J. *Qualitative Research Methods: Collecting Evidence, Crafting Analysis, Communicating Impact*. London: Wiley-Blackwell, 2013.

van Dam, Renske Maria. “Home Within Movement: The Japanese Concept of Ma (間): Sensing Space-Time Intensity in Aesthetics of Movement.” In *Ancient and Modern Practices of Citizenship in Asia and the West: Care of the Self*, edited by Gregory Bracken, 241–58. Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press, 2018.

Welters, Linda, Abby Lillethun, Jean L. Druesedow, and Julia Petrov. “Ptychoseis = Folds + Pleats: Drapery from Ancient Greek Dress to 2lst-Century Fashion.” In *Dress* vol. 31, no. 1 (January 2004): 72–77.

Woodward, Sophie. *Why Women Wear What They Wear*. First edition, Oxford: Berg Publishers, 2007.

Yanagisawa, Elisabet. “The Fold: A Physical Model of Abstract Reversibility and Envelopment.” In *Dark Precursor: Deleuze and Artistic Research*, edited by Paulo De Assis and Paolo Giudici, 1:139–49. Leuven University Press, 2017.

Young, Iris Marion. *On Female Body Experience: Throwing Like a Girl and Other Essays*. Oxford, USA: Oxford University Press, Incorporated, 2005.

Zaki, Terese, Ahmed Negm Eldin, and Ghada Alkholy. “Innovation of Women Garment Designs through Employing Geometrical Pleats Fixed by Heat Setting.” In مجلة العمارة و الفنون و العلوم الإنسانية vol. 8, no. 39 (2023): 637–58.

Internet Sources

Cocks, Jay. “Living: The Man Who’s Changing Clothes.” TIME, October 21, 1985. Accessed January 25, 2025. https://time.com/archive/6705023/living-the-man-whos-changing-clothes/.

Hughes, Natalie. “The History of the Hero: Pleats Please Issey Miyake 30 Years on, Our Appreciation of the Designer’s Iconic Pleats Shows No Sign of Waning.” Harpers Bazaar, August 16, 2023. Accessed January 24, 2025. https://www.harpersbazaar.com/uk/fashion/a44827008/pleats-please-issey-miyake/.

NGV. “Bustier 1980-1981 {autumn-Winter 1980–81} ISSEY MIYAKE, Tokyo (Fashion House) Issey MIYAKE (Designer).” Accessed April 10, 2025. https://www.ngv.vic.gov.au/explore/collection/work/57618/.

Metropolis Editors. “The A to Z of Issey Miyake.” Metropolis, May 10, 2016. Accessed April 3, 2025. https://metropolismag.com/viewpoints/the-a-to-z-of-issey-miyake/.

Rothery, Madeleine. “Four Women on Why They Love Wearing Issey Miyake’s Easygoing Designs.” AnOther, April 19, 2024. Accessed February 2, 2025. https://www.anothermag.com/fashion-beauty/15580/issey-miyake-taschen-book-pleats-please-wearers-laila-gohar-suzy-menkes.

Stockholms universitet/Stockholm University
SE-106 91 Stockholm
Telefon/Phone: 08 – 16 20 00
www.su.se



Stockholms universitet